Asia before Colonial Times

Francis Bond

based on slides by František Kratochvíl

2026

Overview

1. Language Families of Asia
2. South Asia
3. Geography and Climate
4. Crops and Domestication
5. Contact, Trade and Writing
6. Lexical Borrowing
7. Conclusion

The region in numbers

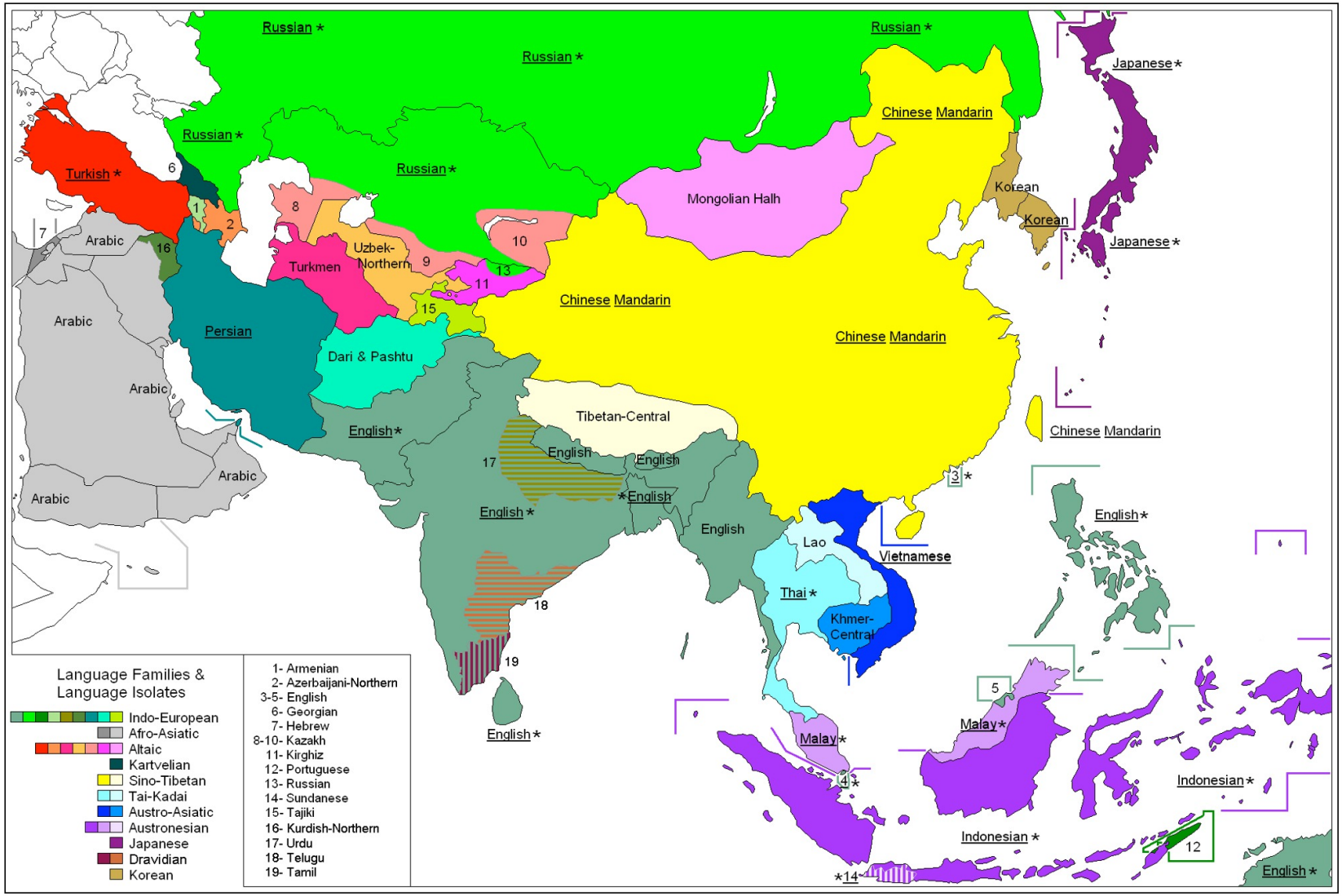
- From the Indian subcontinent to the Indonesian archipelago:
  - about **2,000 languages** (roughly **30%** of the 7,000 spoken on the planet)
  - about **one third of humanity**
- South Asia alone: **1.8 billion** people in eight countries, speaking some **664** languages
- Eight or so phyla: Austroasiatic, Austronesian, Dravidian, Hmong-Mien, Indo-Aryan, Sino-Tibetan, Tai-Kadai, and several Papuan families
- Plus isolates with no known relatives: **Burushaski** (N. Pakistan), **Nihali** (central-west India), **Kusunda** (western Nepal)

Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020; Hammarström et al. 2018; Eberhard et al. 2019

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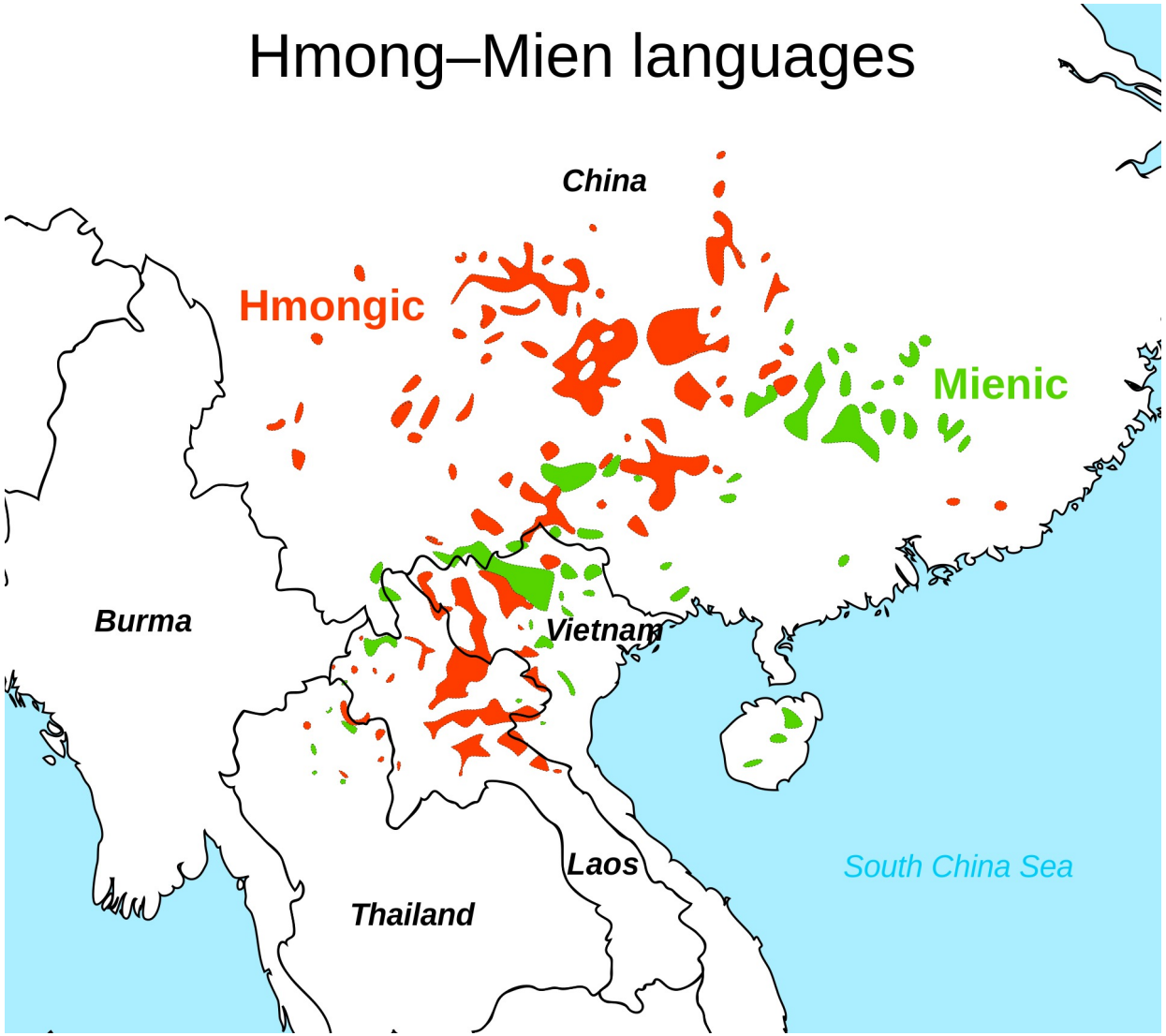
Major languages of Asia



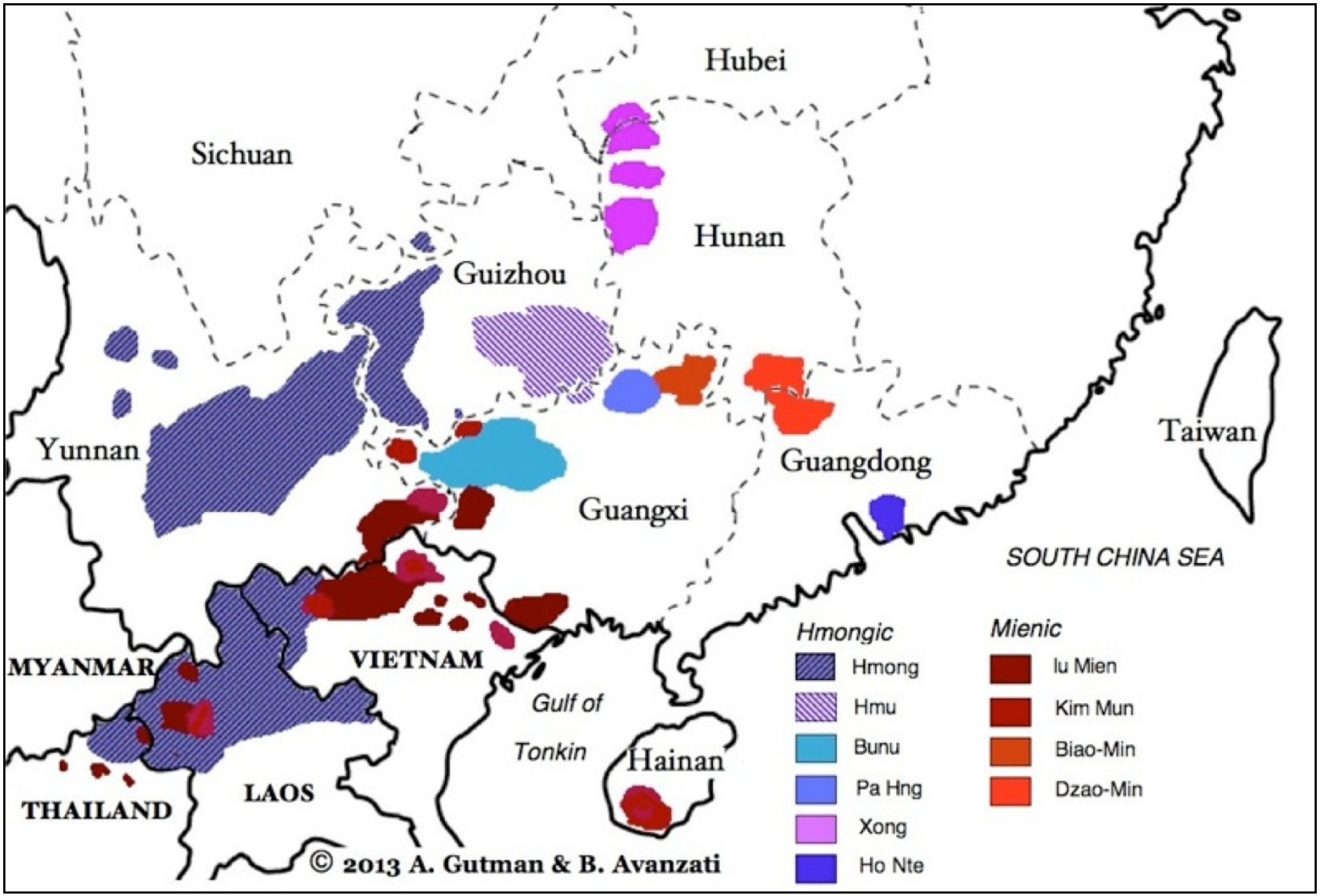
Austro-Asiatic family



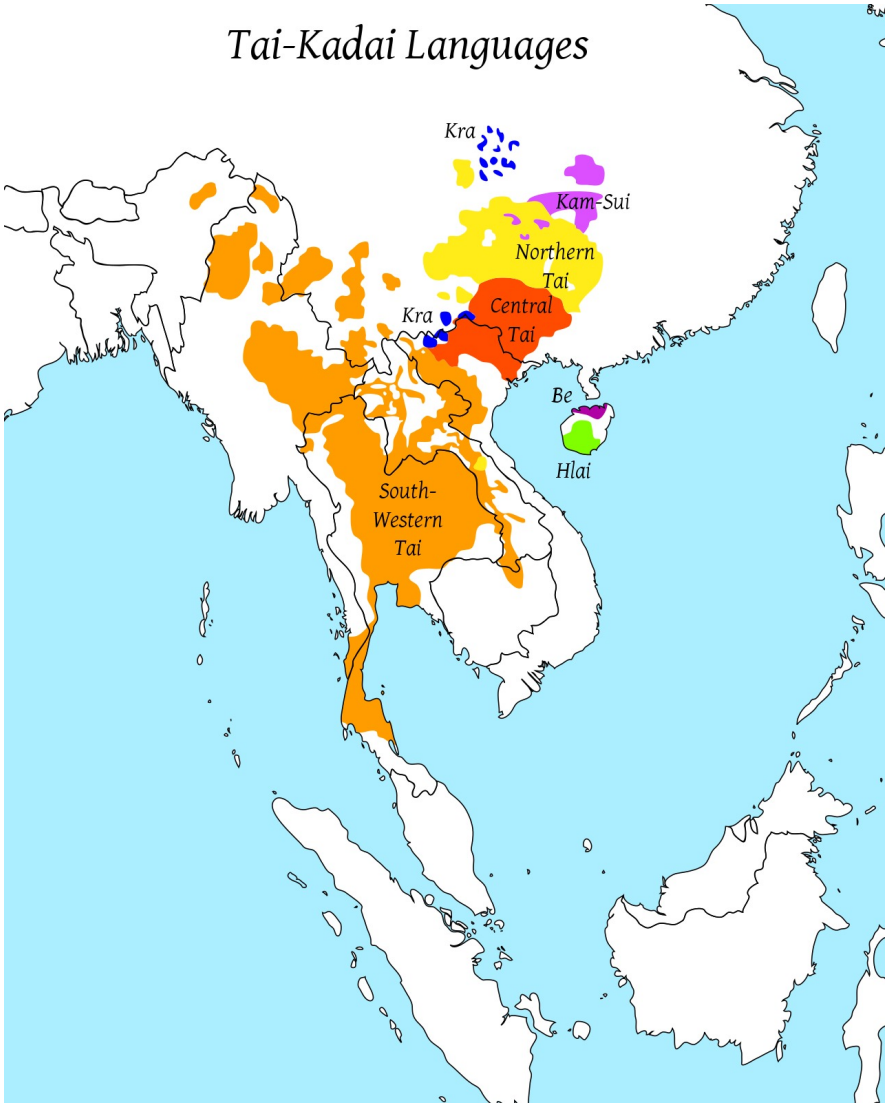
Hmong-Mien family



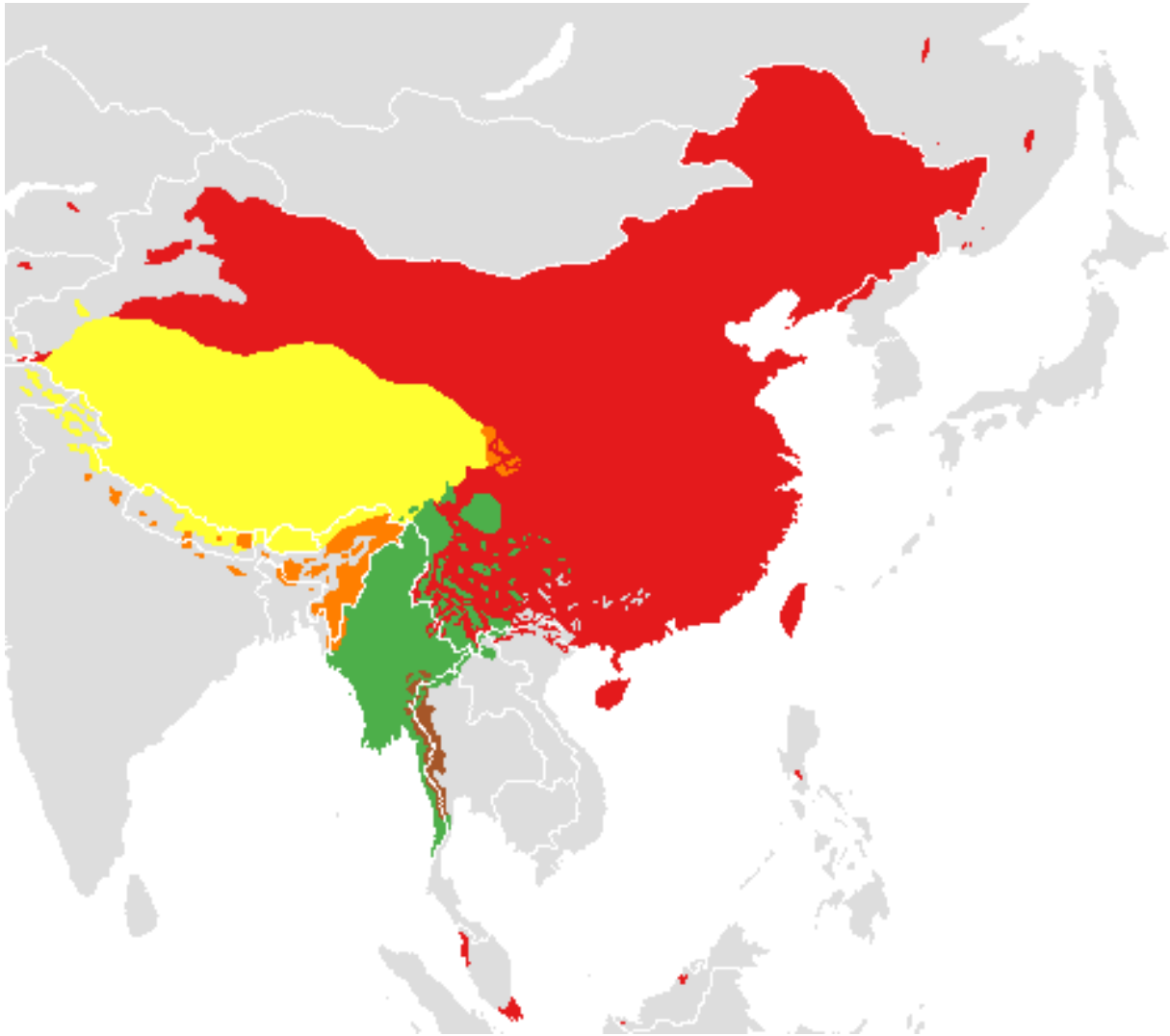
Hmong-Mien family



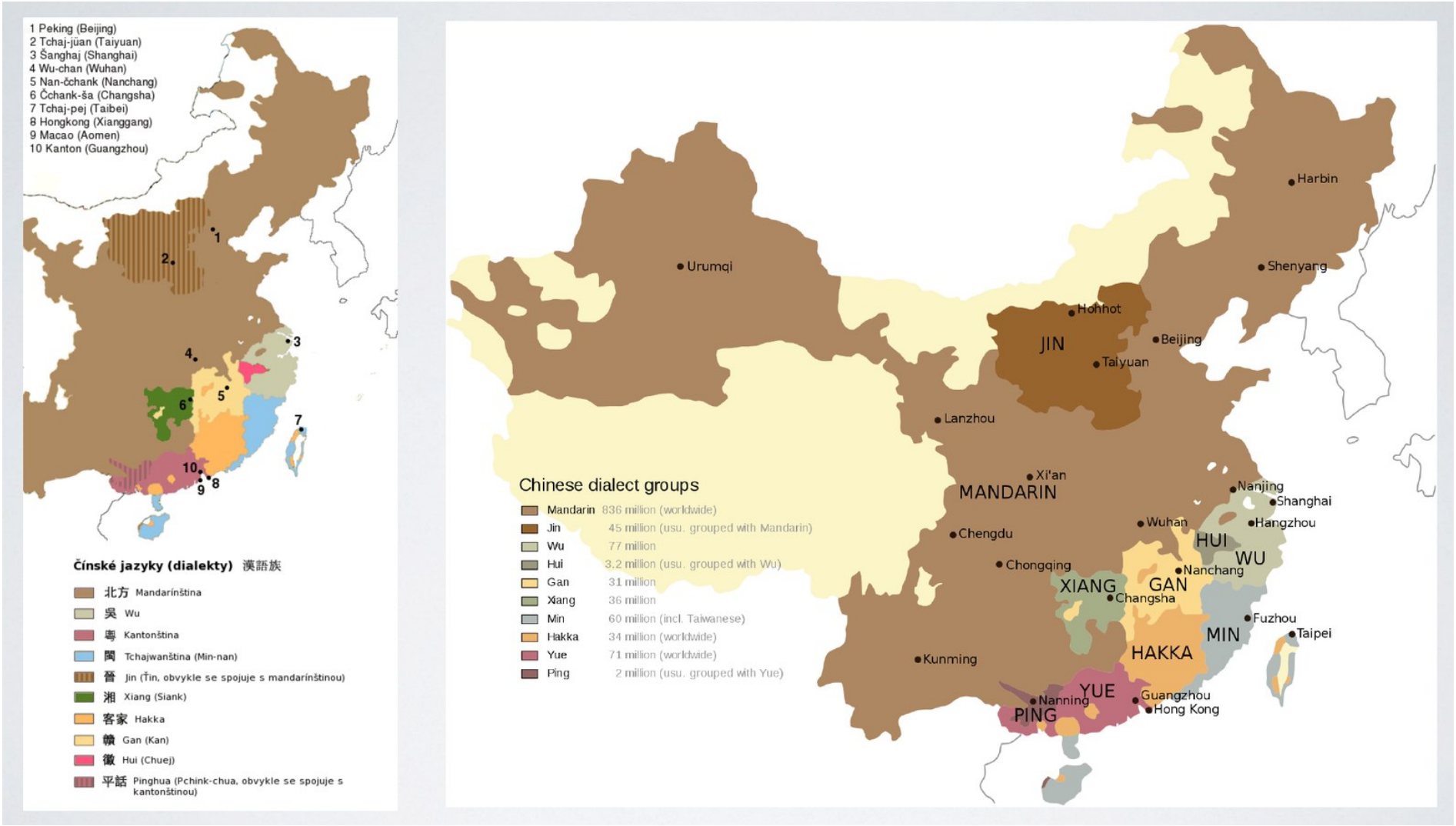
Tai-Kadai family (probably a branch of Austronesian)



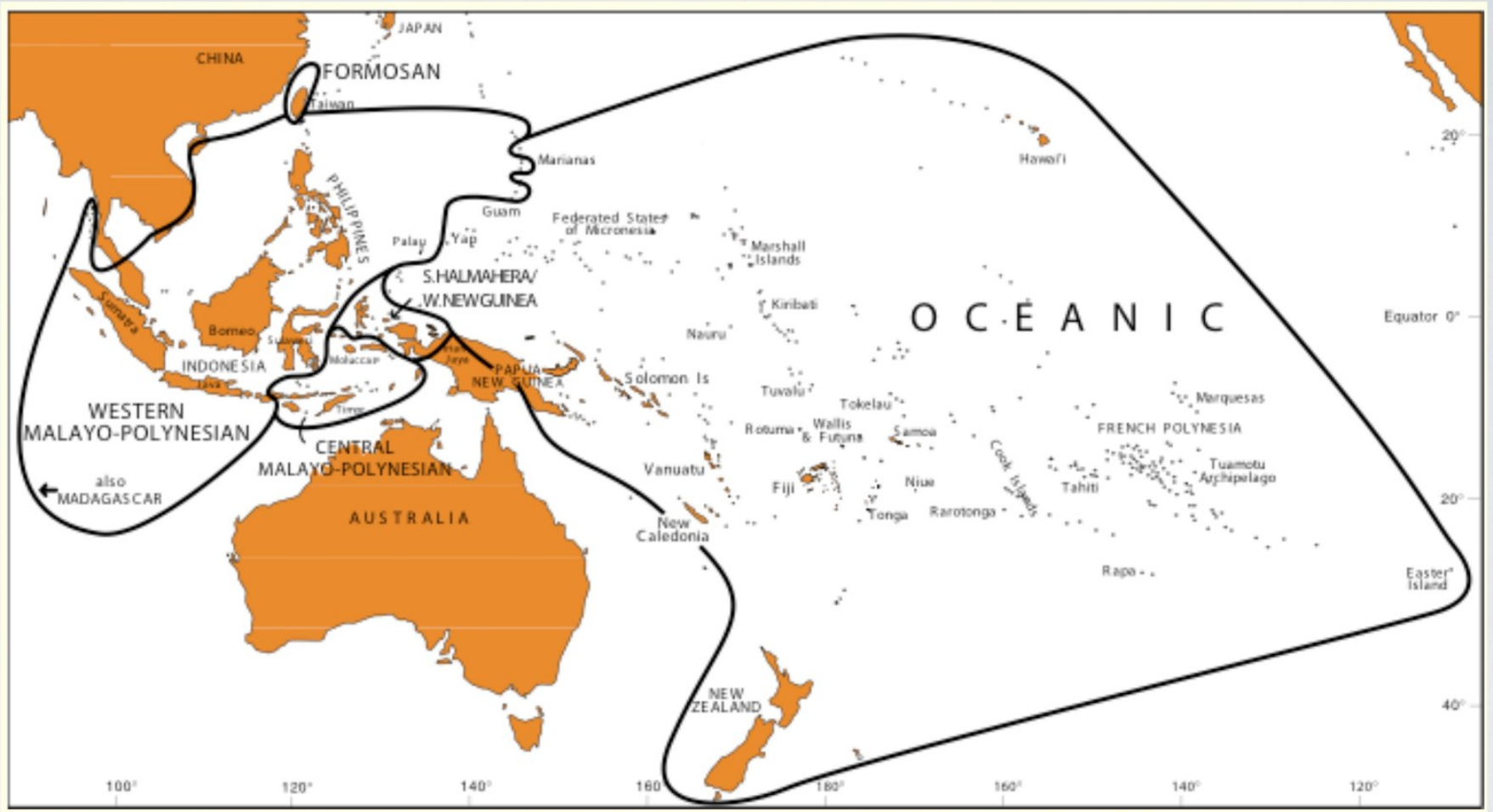
Sino-Tibetan family



Sinitic branch



The integrity of the Austronesian language family



Ross 2009

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Who was in South Asia first?

- Five families, plus three isolates:
  - **Austroasiatic** (Munda, Khasic), **Dravidian**, **Indo-European** (Indo-Aryan, Iranian, Nuristani), **Sino-Tibetan** (Tibeto-Burman), **Tai-Kadai**
- **Munda** speakers predate the Indo-Aryan migration
  - Munda place names in the Dravidian Kurukh- and Malto-speaking regions
- **Dravidian** is probably autochthonous (native to where it is spoken)
  - Proto-Dravidian may have been the language of the Indus Civilization
  - non-Indo-Aryan place names (toponyms) survive in northern India
- The Khasi and Jaintia Hills languages look like a later arrival from the east: MSEA-like features, unlike Munda

Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 19–21

Dating a text by what it omits

- The **Ṛgveda** (1500-1000 BCE) never mentions iron
  - so it predates c. 1000 BCE, when iron appears in South Asia
- It knows the cities of the Indus Valley Civilization only as ruins
  - so it postdates their collapse around 1900 BCE
- That brackets both the text and the Aryan migration at roughly **1500 BCE**
- Dravidian loanwords in Vedic Sanskrit suggest early contact: *ulūkhala-* 'mortar', *kuṇḍa* 'pit', *khála-* 'threshing floor', *kāṇa* 'one-eyed', *mayūra* 'peacock'

Witzel 2001; Emeneau 1954; Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 20, 29

Assam: a Tai kingdom, an Indo-Aryan language

- 13th century: a tribe of Shans crosses the Patkai range and founds a kingdom that lasts 600 years
  - their language, **Ahom**, gives **Assam** its name
- Ahom is now dead, but modern **Assamese** (Indo-Aryan) carries its imprint:
  - lost the dental ∼ retroflex contrast in stops, unusual for Indo-Aryan (the orthography still writes both)
  - an extensive numeral classifier system, common in MSEA but only rudimentary elsewhere in Indo-Aryan
- River names preserve an older layer still
  - Tai *nam* 'water' in the Namphuk
  - a *di/ti* formative in the Dehing, Dikhu, Disang, Tizü and Tiho, from Proto-Tibeto-Burman **ti(y)* 'water'

Gait 1906; Benedict 1972; Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 21–22

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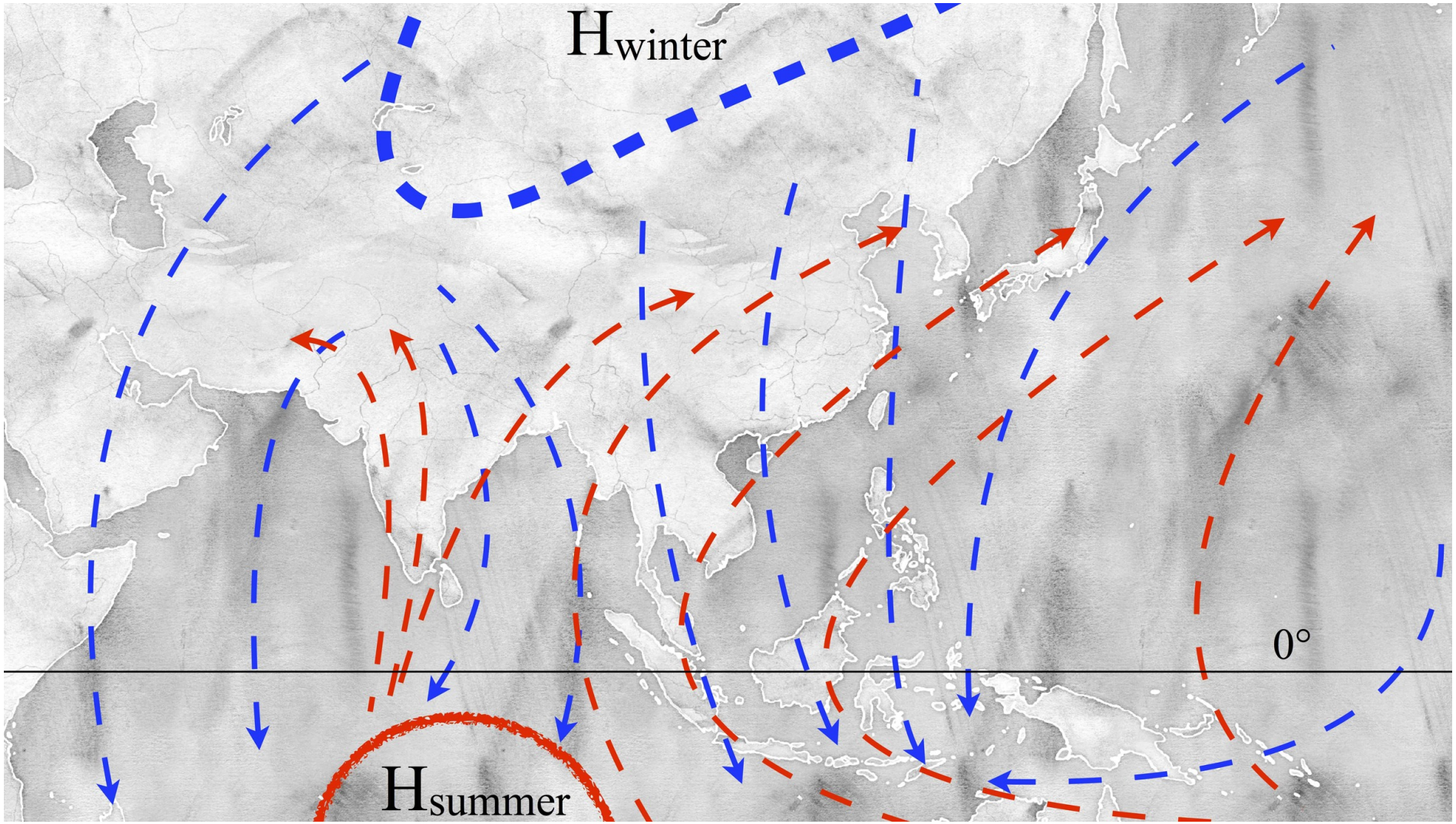
Relief of East and Southeast Asia



Relief of mainland Southeast Asia



Monsoon patterns



Zomia: the uplands as refuge

- Scott (2009) calls the uplands of Southeast Asia and beyond **Zomia**
  - a refuge for minorities fleeing the corvée (intermittent forced unpaid labour) and taxation of the lowland padi states
- In MSEA the main booty of a campaign was manpower: Thai *kwàːt mɯːang*, literally ‘sweep city’
- Whole communities were carried off to Tai and Burmese padi states to work the wet rice fields
- Concentrated labour encourages a shift to the language of the rulers
- Lowlands consolidate into few big languages, uplands preserve many small ones

Scott 2009; Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 22, 42

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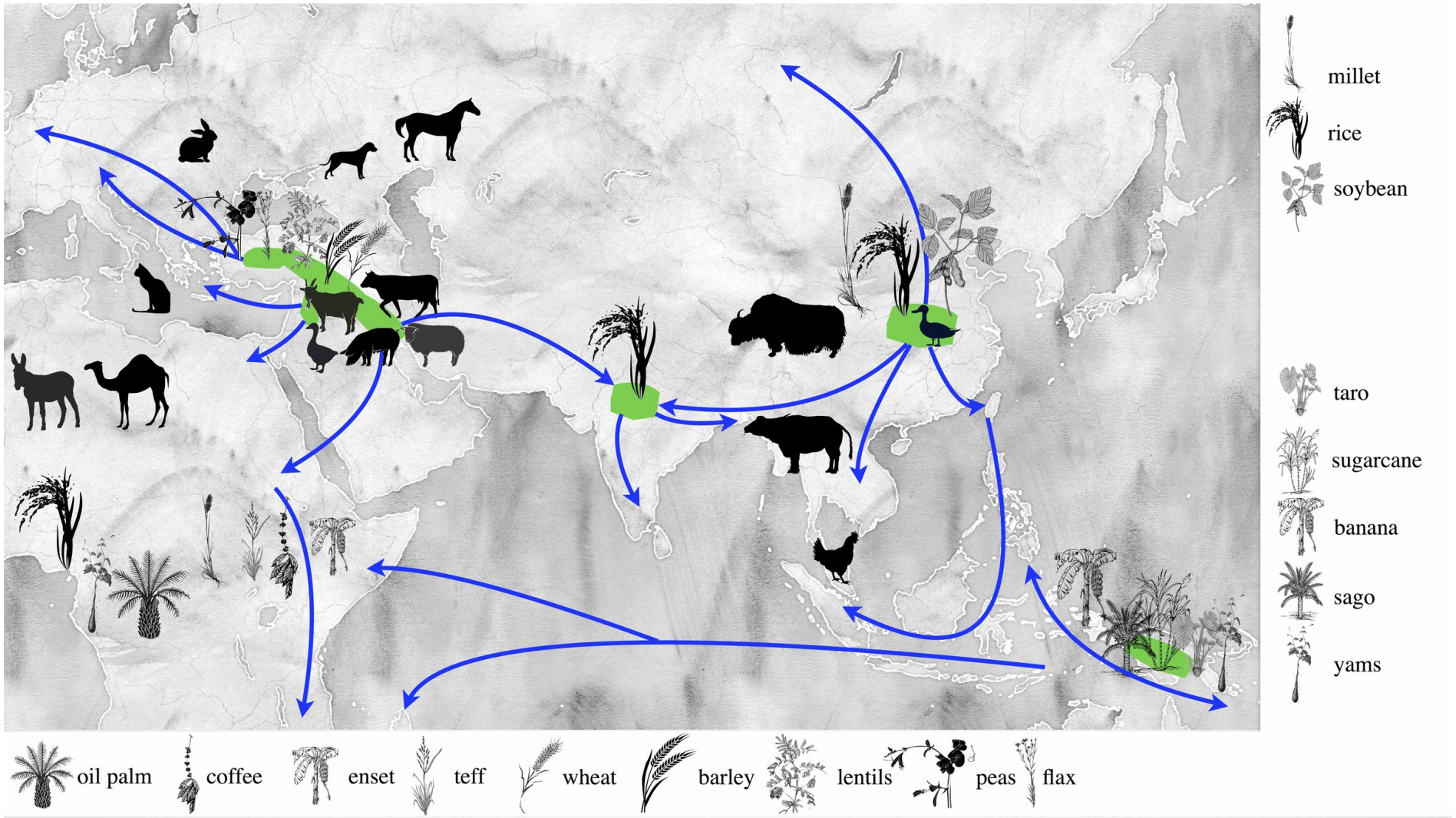
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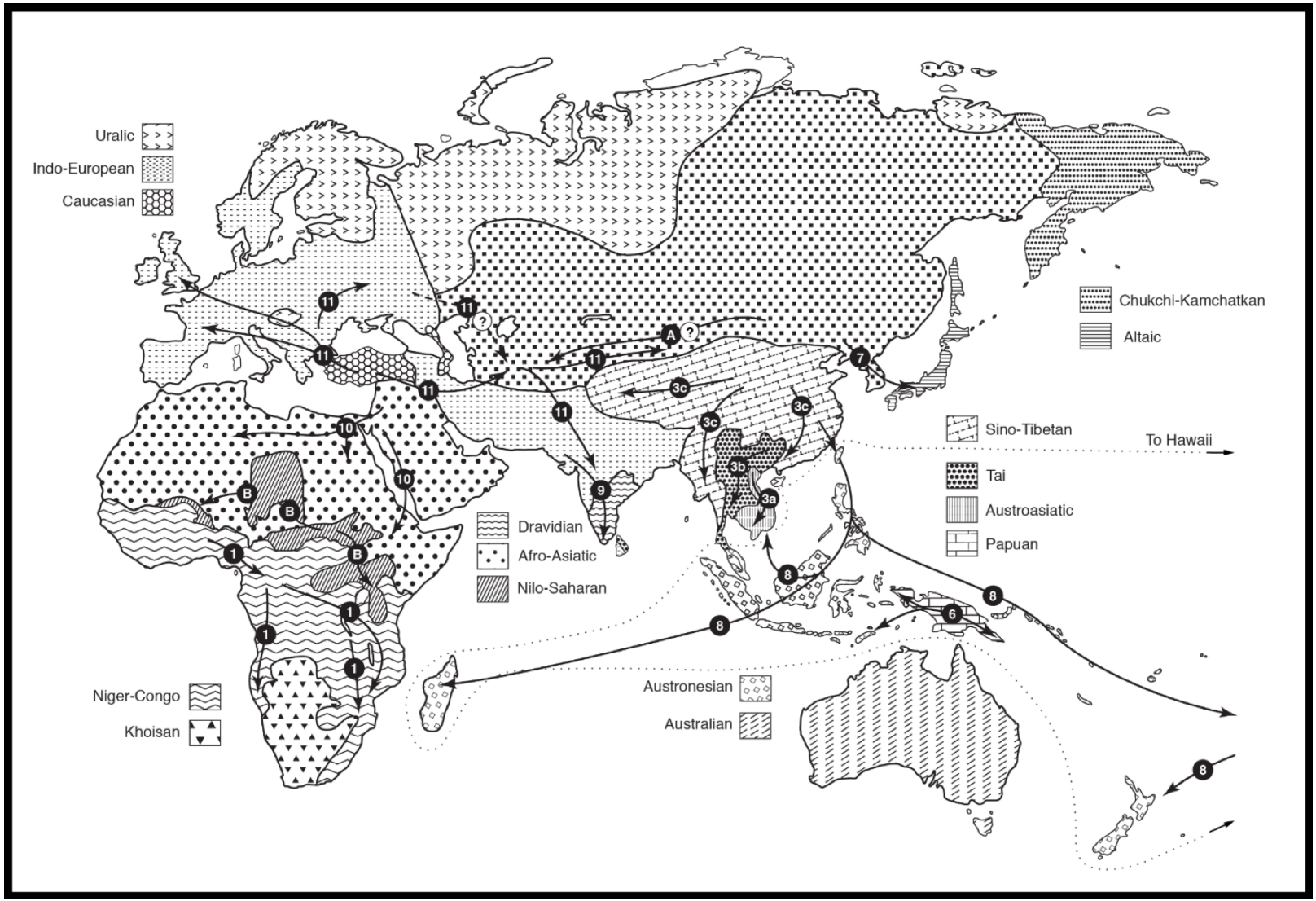
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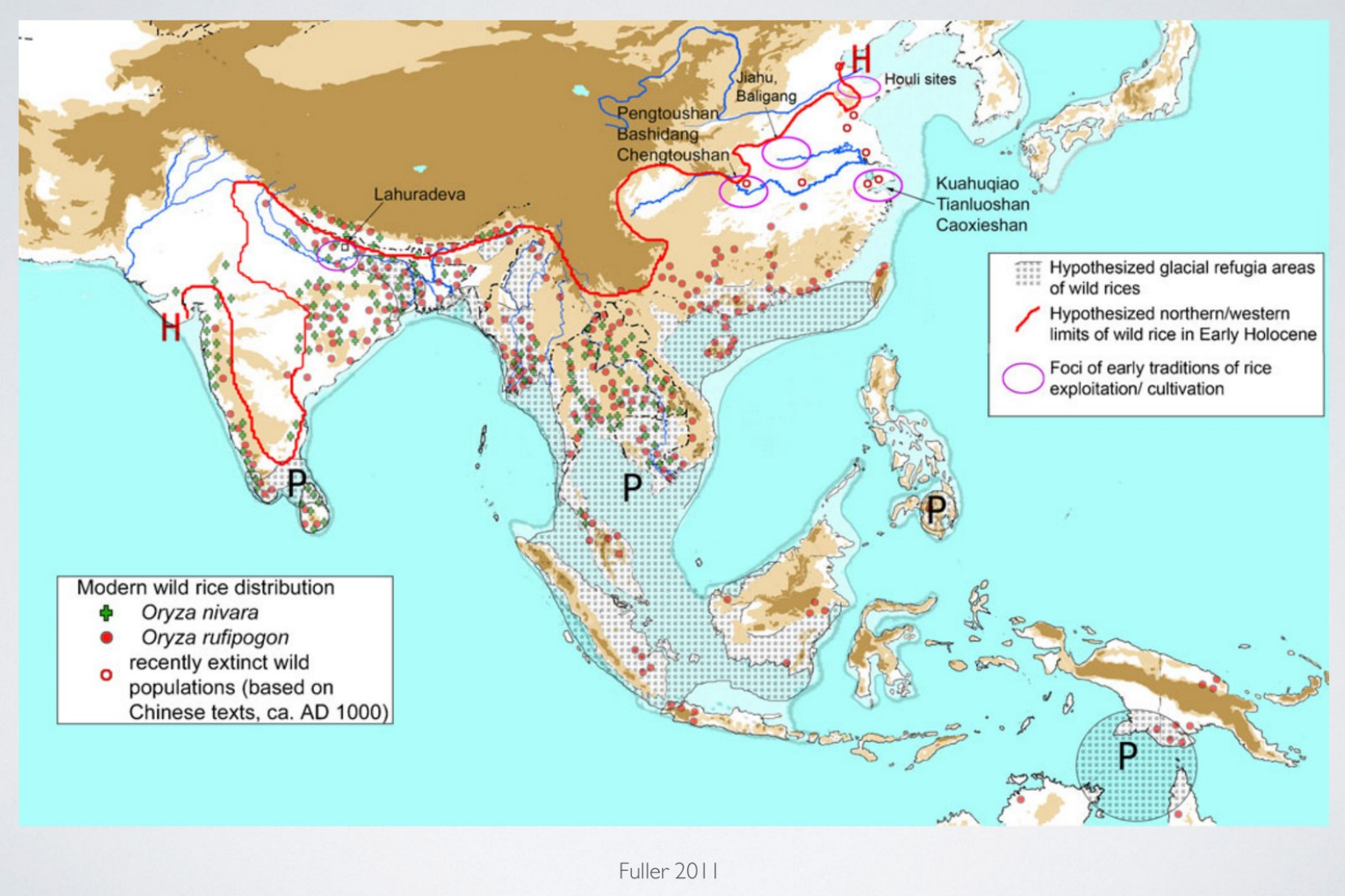
Cultural crops



Cultural crops and language family expansions

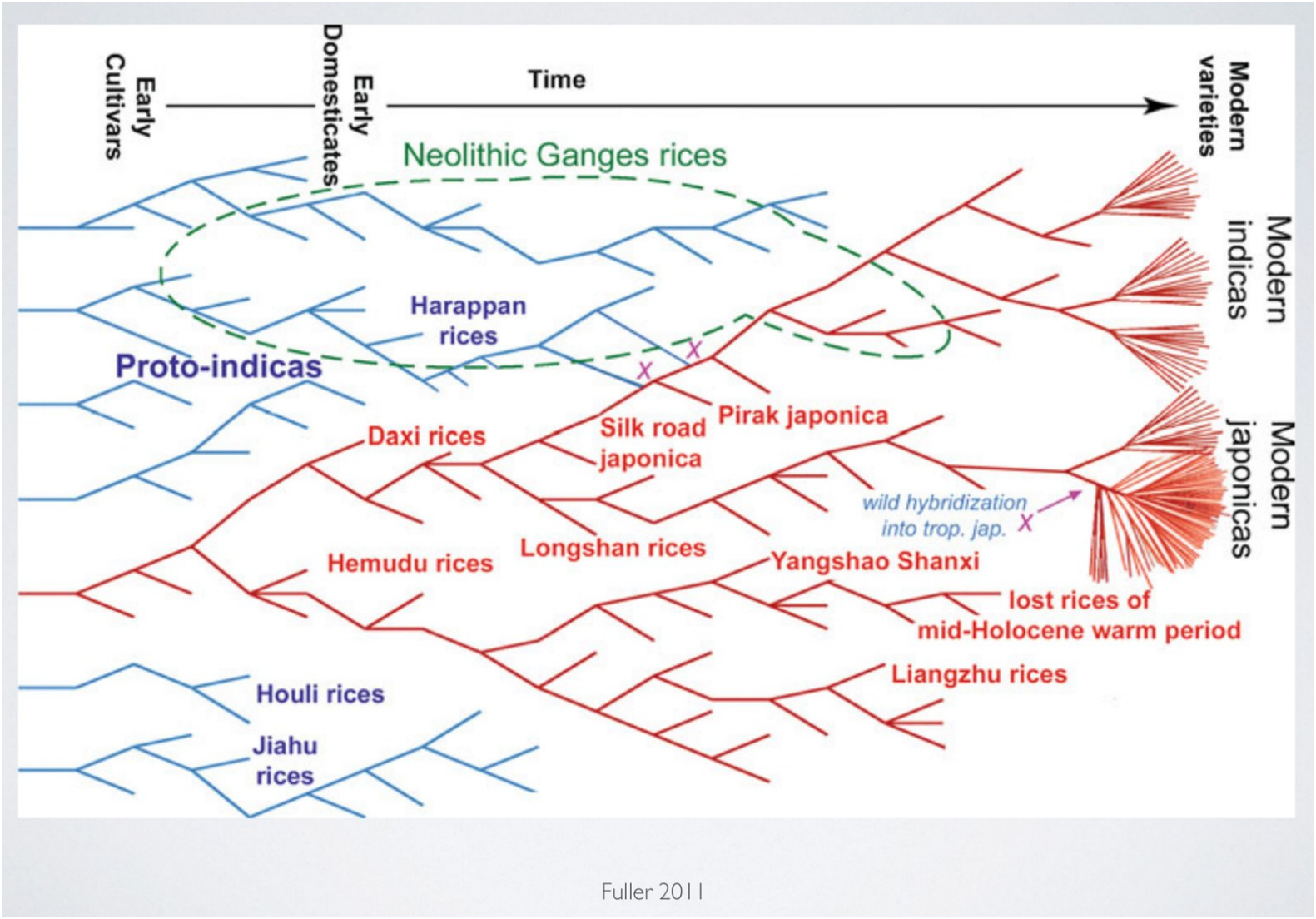


Last glacial period sea levels and natural refugia of wild rice

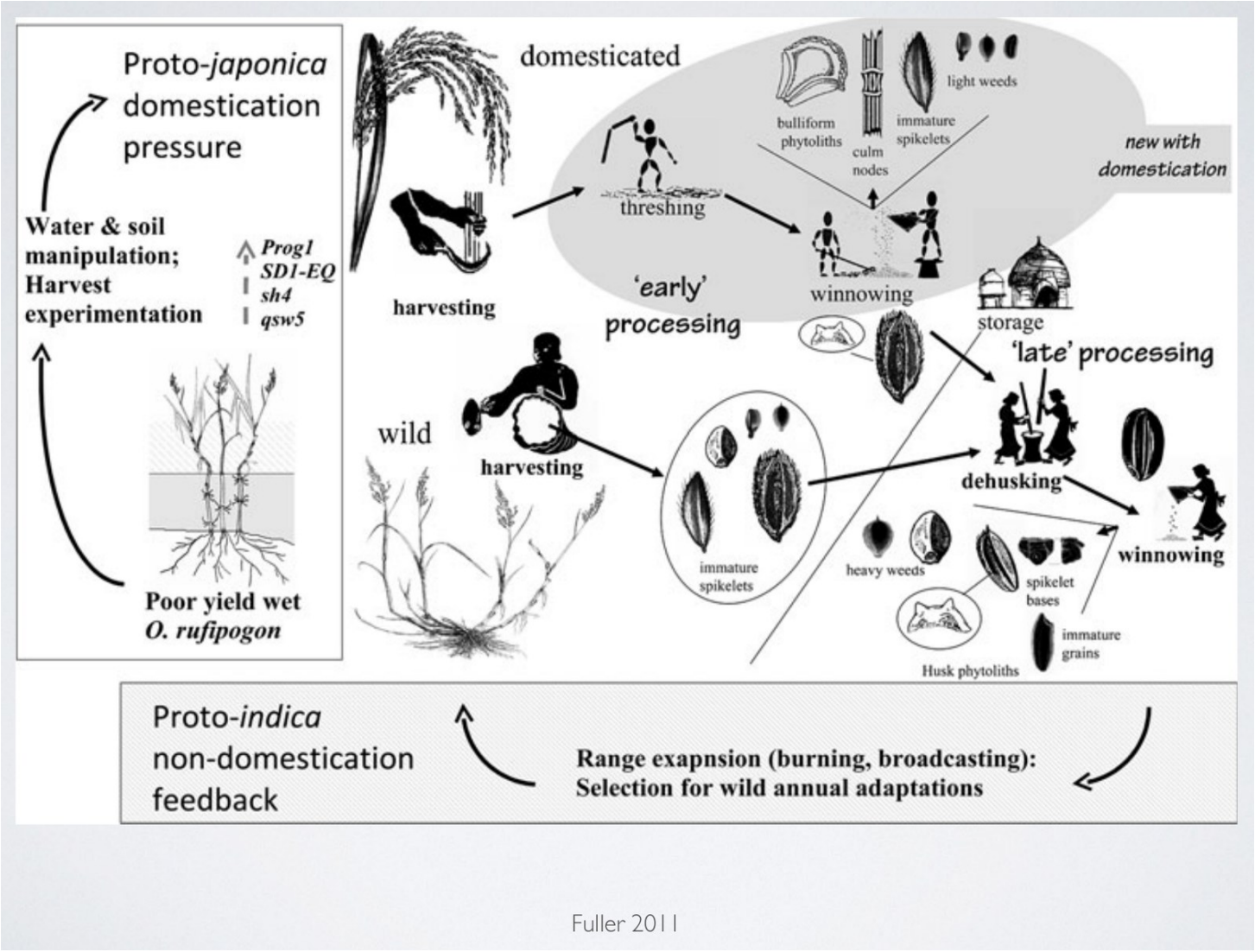


Fuller 2011

Genetic diversity of rice

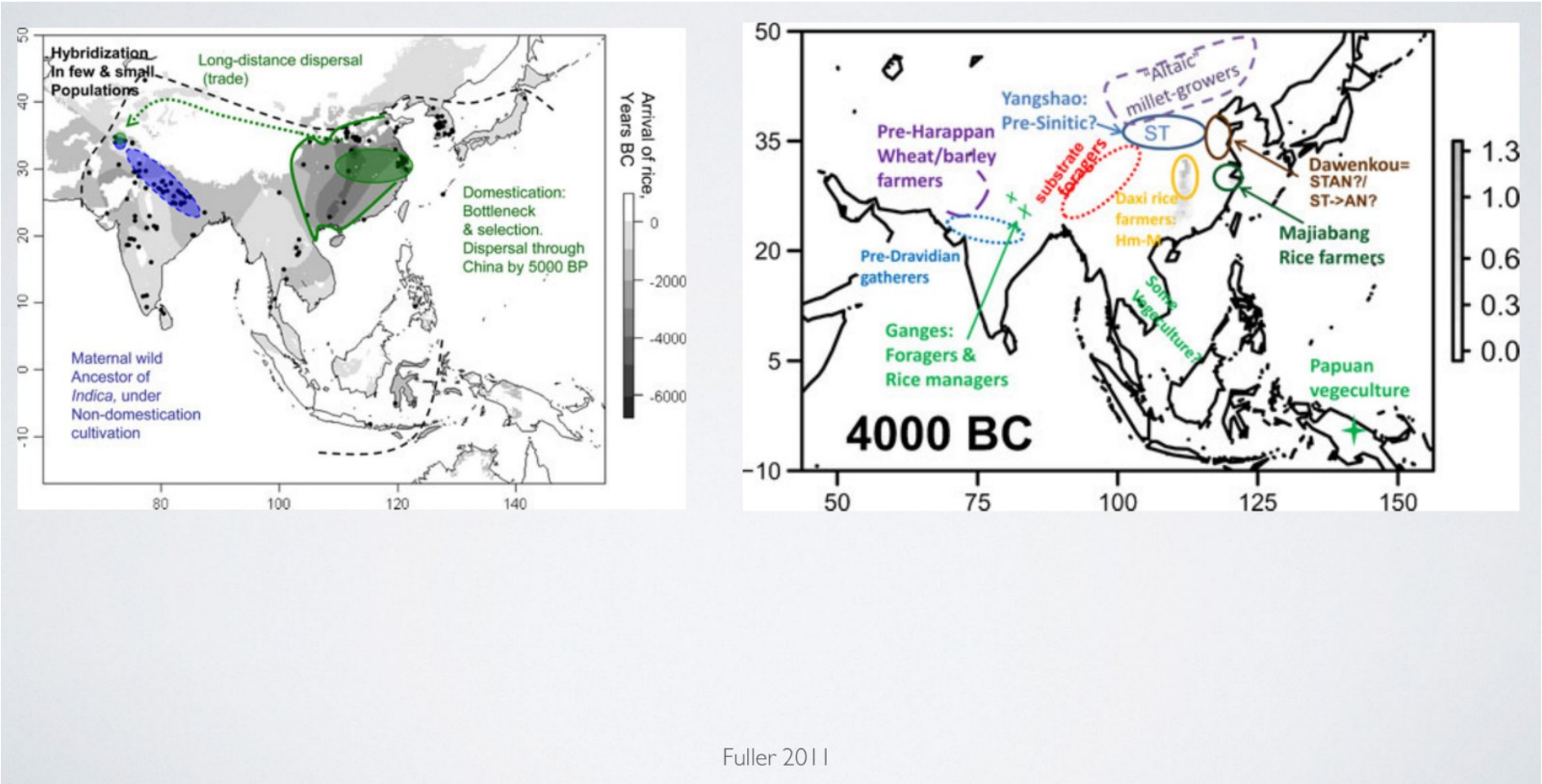


Domestication pressures on rice



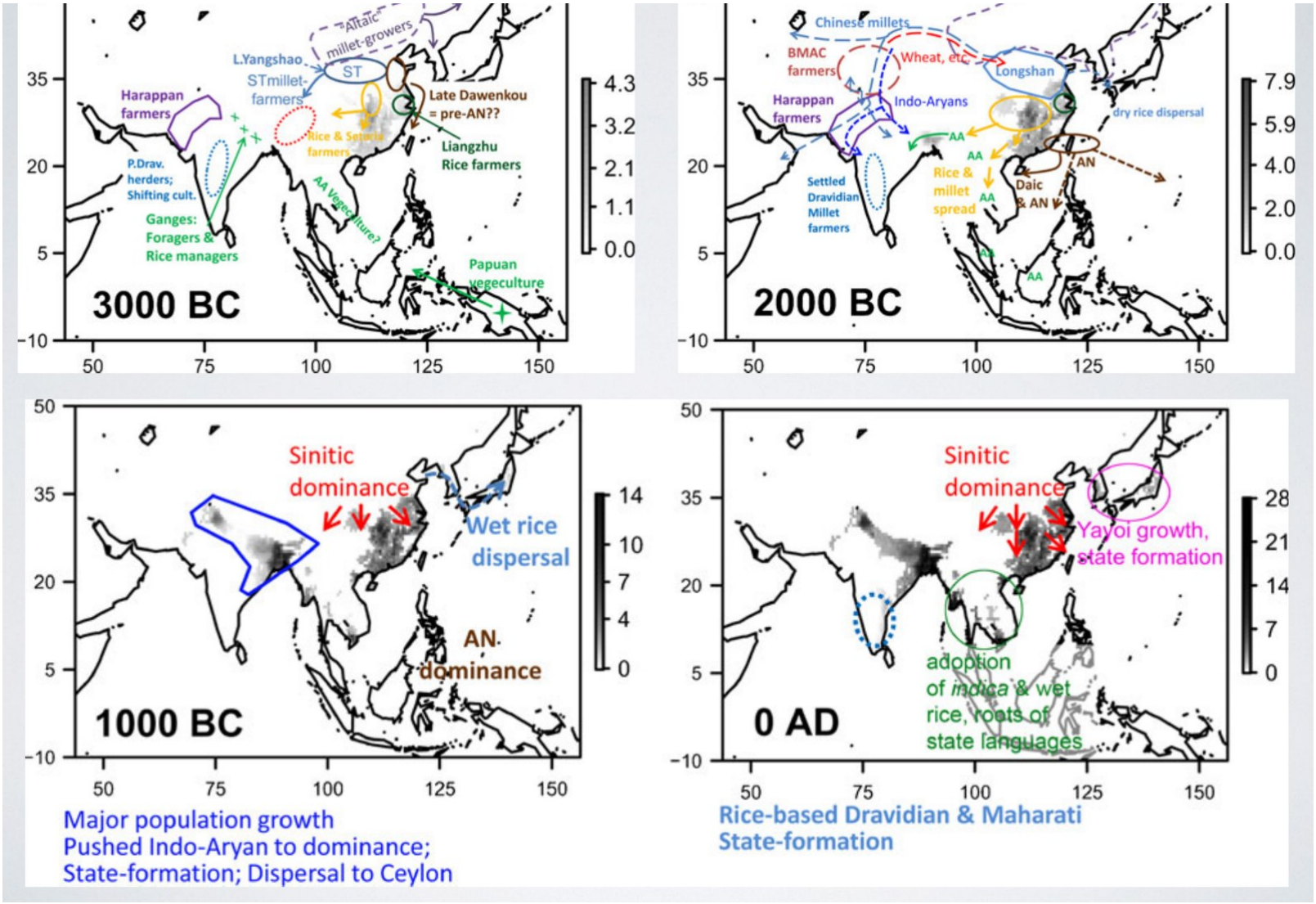
Fuller 2011

Spreading of rice hybrids

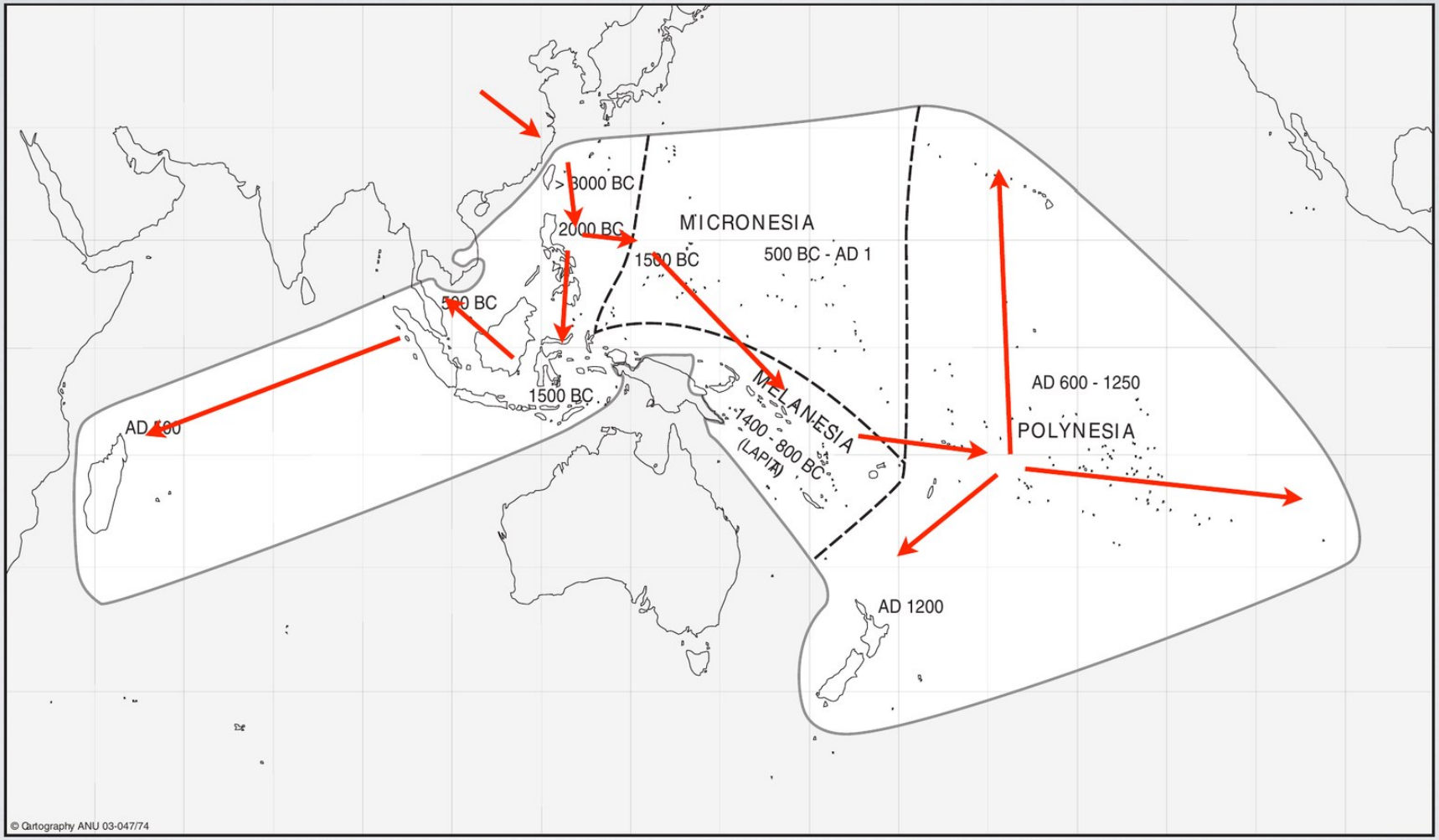


Fuller 2011

Spreading of rice hybrids



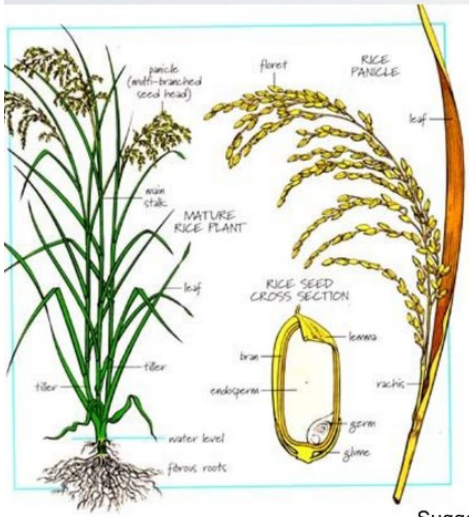
Reconstruction of Austronesian expansion

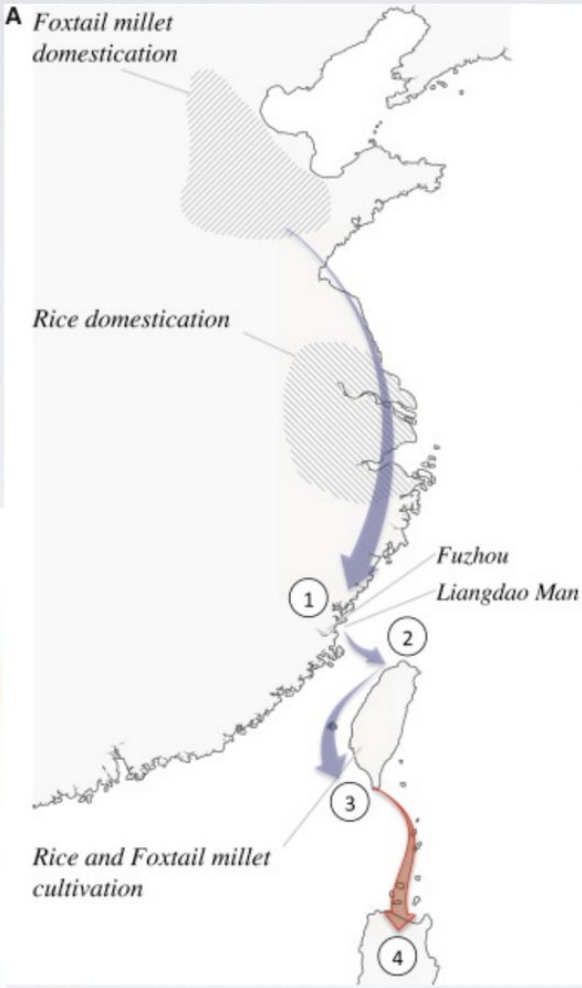


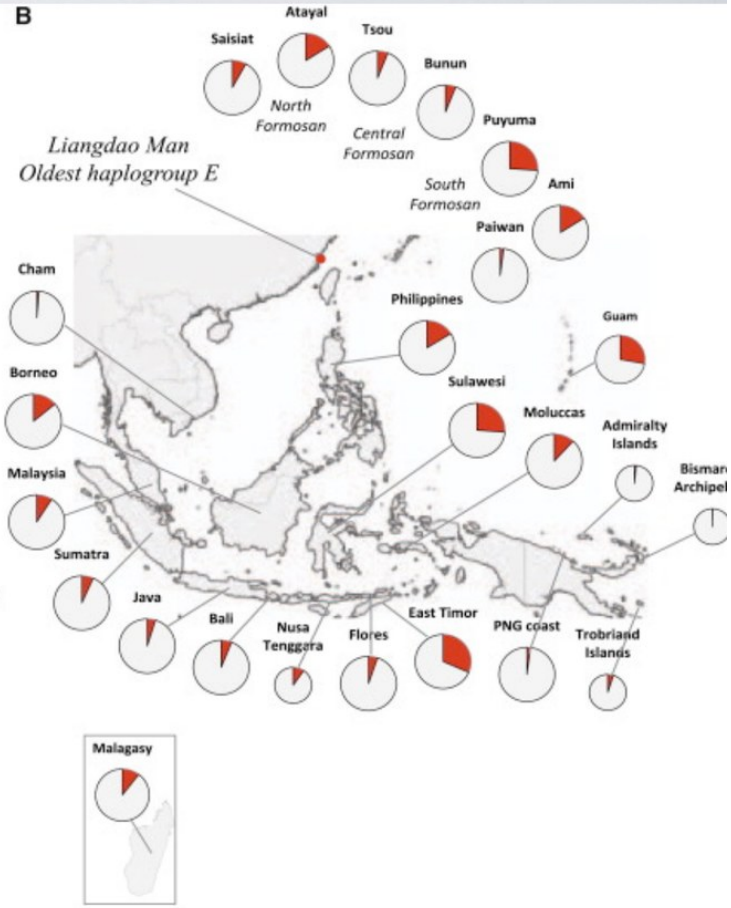
Bellwood and Dizon 2008

Millets





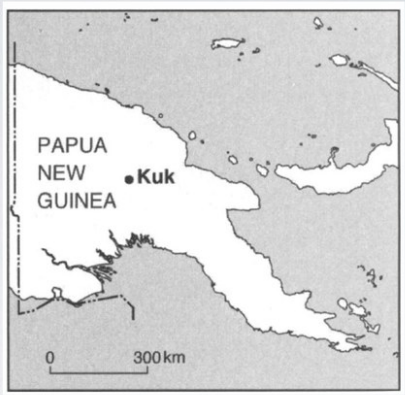




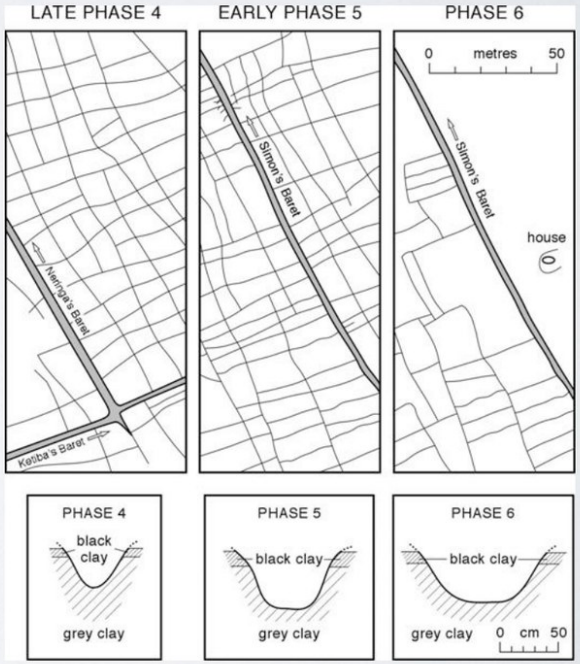
Suggested Migration Route for Early Austronesians Into and Out of Taiwan and the Worldwide Distribution of Haplogroup E1 (A) Geographic regions in China of foxtail millet domestication (source: Ko et al. 2014)

Taro domestication

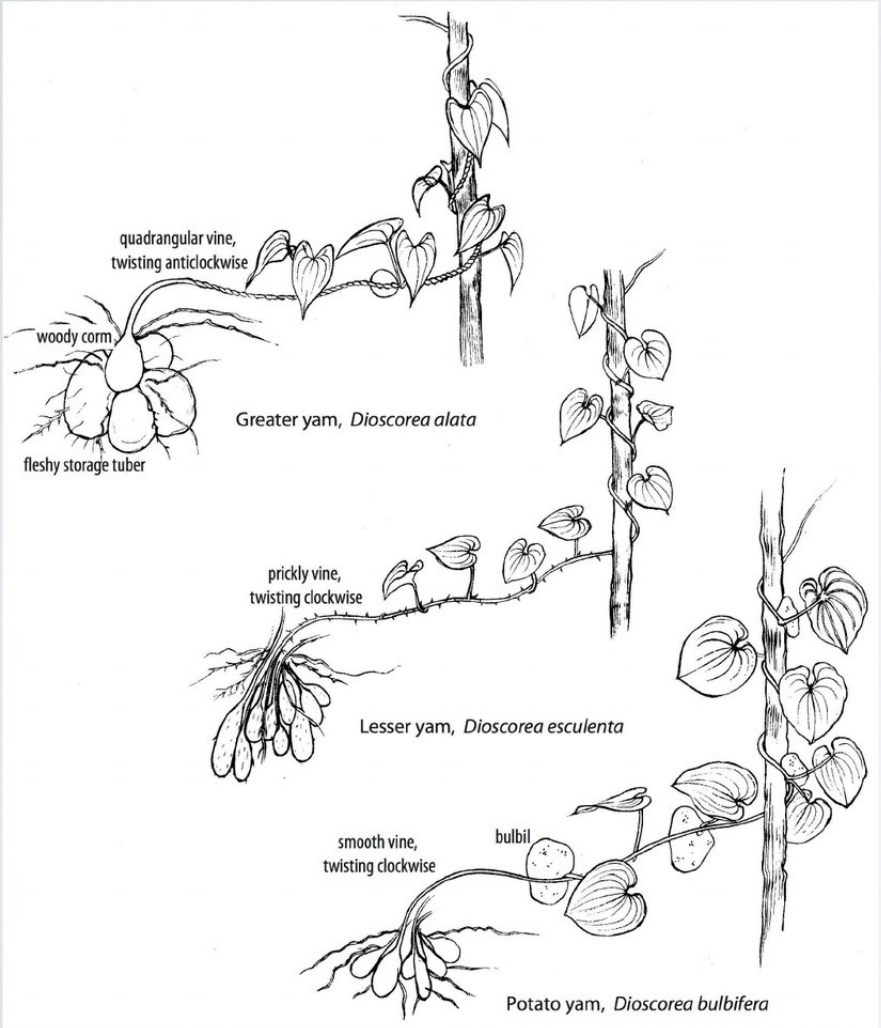
Multidisciplinary investigations at Kuk Swamp in the Highlands of Papua New Guinea show that agriculture arose independently in New Guinea by at least 6950 to 6440 calibrated years before the present (cal yr B.P.). Plant exploitation and some cultivation occurred on the wetland margin at 10,220 to 9910 cal yr B.P. (phase 1), mounding cultivation began by 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P. (phase 2), and ditched cultivation began by 4350 to 3980 cal yr B.P. (phase 3). Clearance of lower montane rainforests began in the early Holocene, with modification to grassland at 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P. Taro (*Colocasia esculenta*) was utilized in the early Holocene, and bananas (*Musa* spp.) were intensively cultivated by at least 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P.

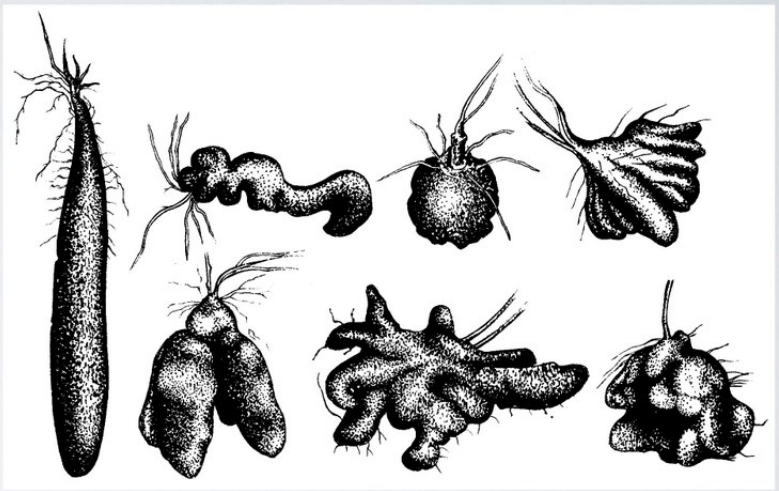




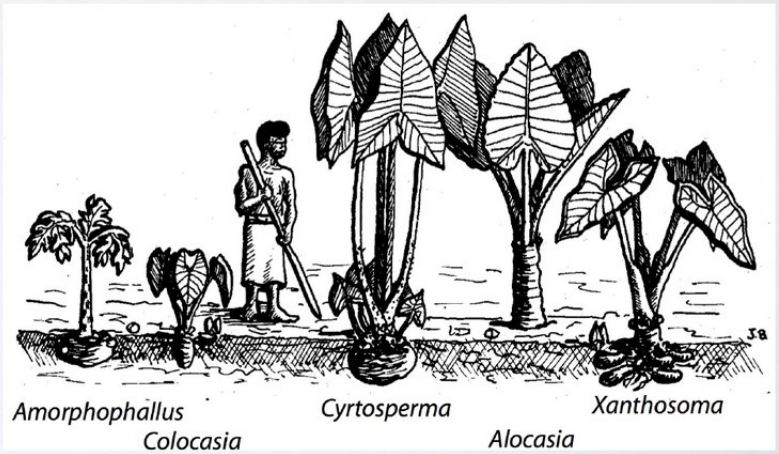


New Guinean domestications: tubers



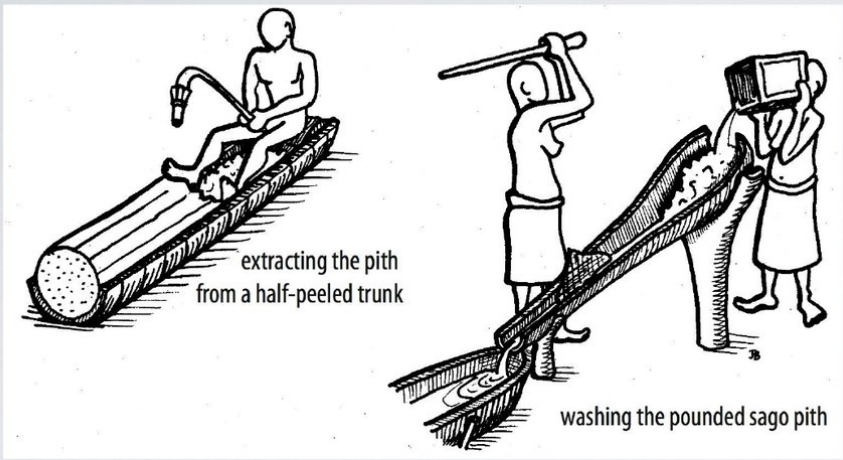


Yams (*Dioscorea alata*)



Taro (*Araceae*) and *Amorphophallus*

New Guinean domestications: sago







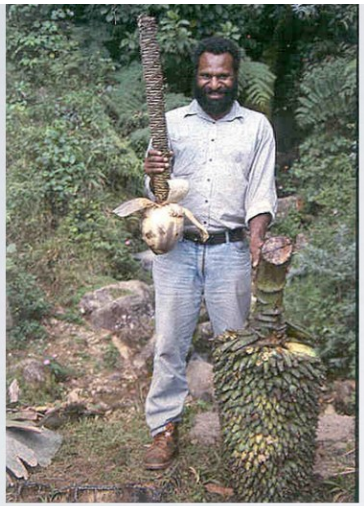


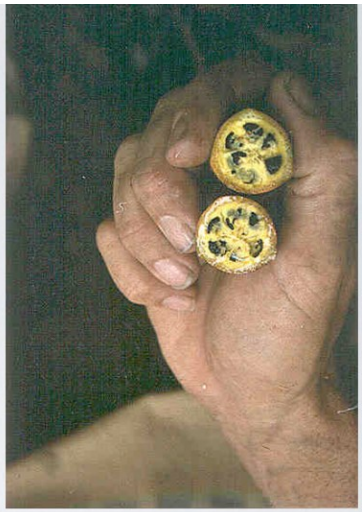




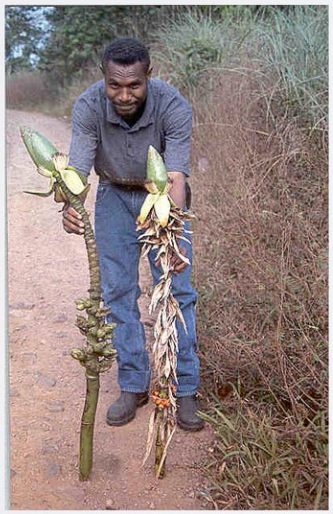


New Guinean domestications: banana



Over 100 new accessions of wild and cultivated bananas were obtained from a wide geographic region including West New Britain, East New Britain, New Ireland, Western Highlands, East Sepik, Madang and Milne Bay


New Guinean domestications: sugar cane











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Indosphere and Sinosphere

- Southeast Asia is the interface between two large states, India and China, and has always felt their pull
- Matisoff (1991) coined **Indosphere** and **Sinosphere** for their overlapping domains of cultural and linguistic influence
- Blust's four periods of influence: **(i) Indian**, **(ii) Chinese**, **(iii) Islamic**, **(iv) European**
- Chinese contact with Southeast Asia was commercial: it did not spread Chinese literacy southward, as it did to Korea, Japan and northern Vietnam

? Which sphere is a given language in? Often both, in different parts of the lexicon

Matisoff 1991; Blust 2009; Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 27, 31

Three degrees of contact

- From weakest to strongest:
- **Lexical borrowing**: a word moves from one language to another
  - religious terms from Hinduism, Buddhism and Islam diffused across the whole area this way
- **Structural borrowing / convergence**: the organising principles of two languages align (phonology, word order, pragmatics)
  - needs bilingual, cohabiting speakers
  - the particle *lah* in Singapore Colloquial English, Malay and Chinese
- **Language shift**: the subjugated community gives up its language for the dominant one
  - the substrate survives in place names and specialist vocabulary
- Shift to national languages is now happening across the whole region, and is expected to reduce diversity sharply this century

Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 28–29

Three contact zones

- **The Indian subcontinent**: Indo-Aryan meets Dravidian
  - the South Asian areal features (dental ∼ retroflex contrast, suffixing morphology, verb-final order, dative subjects) may largely be a contact outcome
- **Mainland Southeast Asia**: five families, and the greatest extent of linguistic convergence on the planet (Enfield 2011)
  - one grammatical template can replicate the same sentence in unrelated languages; often only the words differ
- **Around New Guinea**: Austronesian meets Papuan, giving the East Nusantara area
  - both sides underwent structural simplification
- Expanding agriculturists usually absorbed hunter-gatherers, but not other food producers: the **Neolithic standoff** of eastern Indonesia

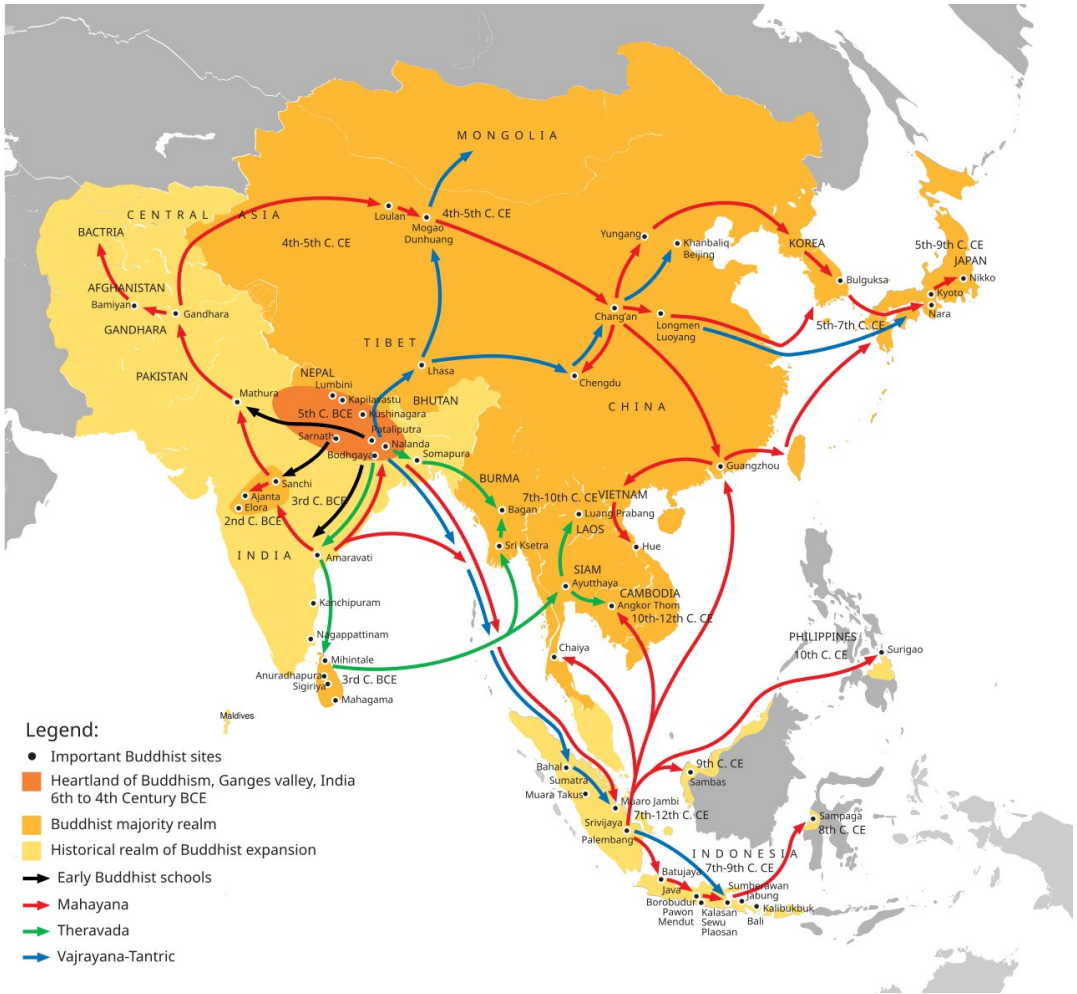
Bisang 1996; Klamer 2004, 2012; Lansing et al. 2011; Enfield 2011

Malay: the lingua franca for two millennia

- Malay was the de facto **lingua franca** of island Southeast Asia for almost two thousand years (stone inscriptions from the 7th century CE)
- Not displaced by Javanese, Chinese, Arabic, Portuguese or Dutch: only by English, around the Second World War
- It carried the prestige of the Hindu, Buddhist and Islamic periods, and was the main conduit for Islam
  - *masuk Melayu* 'enter Malay' meant both converting to Islam and shifting to Malay
- Malay was also the intermediary for Sanskrit, Tamil, Persian and Arabic loans across the region (so the loanword charts below run through Malay)

Adelaar & Prentice 1996; Blust 2009; Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 33–34

The spread of Buddhism



Map by Gunawan Kartapranata, via Wikimedia Commons (*Buddhist Expansion.svg*), CC BY-SA 3.0

Vietnamese: the one script imposed by conquest

- Writing reached MSEA and ISEA with religious texts, in **Brāhmī-based abugidas** from South India
  - Burmese, Khmer, Lao, Mon, Shan and Thai (essentially every Theravada Buddhist language)
- **Vietnamese is the exception**: the only Austroasiatic language of MSEA without an Indic-derived script
  - the only writing system in the region imposed by a conquering power
- Classical Chinese logographs after the Han invasion of 111 BCE, then **chữ Nôm**, with characters added for what Chinese could not write
- 17th-century Catholic missionaries devised a Roman script with diacritics for the tones that had developed under Sinitic domination
  - the French administration made it official in the early 20th century

Court 1996; Nguyễn 1996; Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 31, 34

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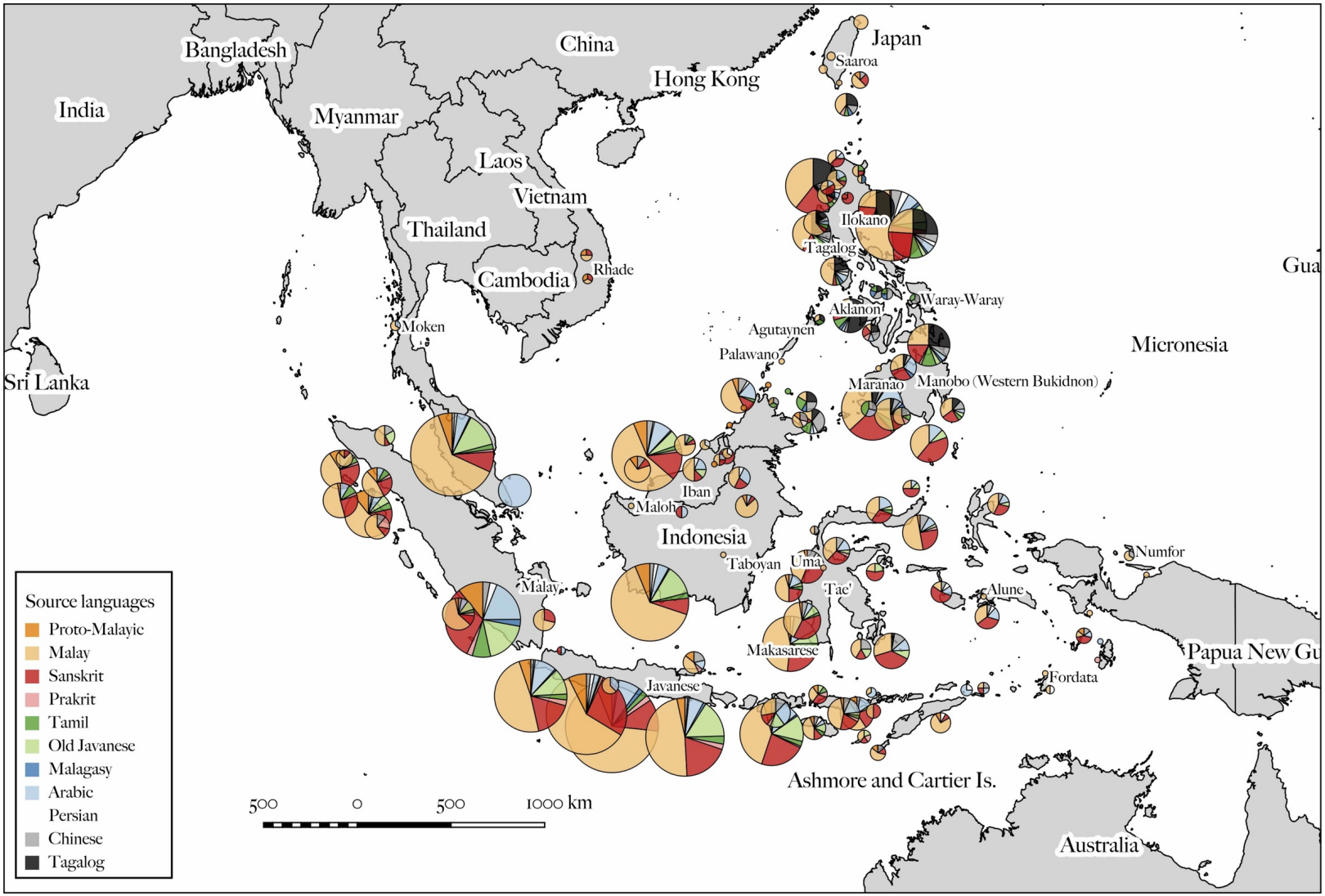
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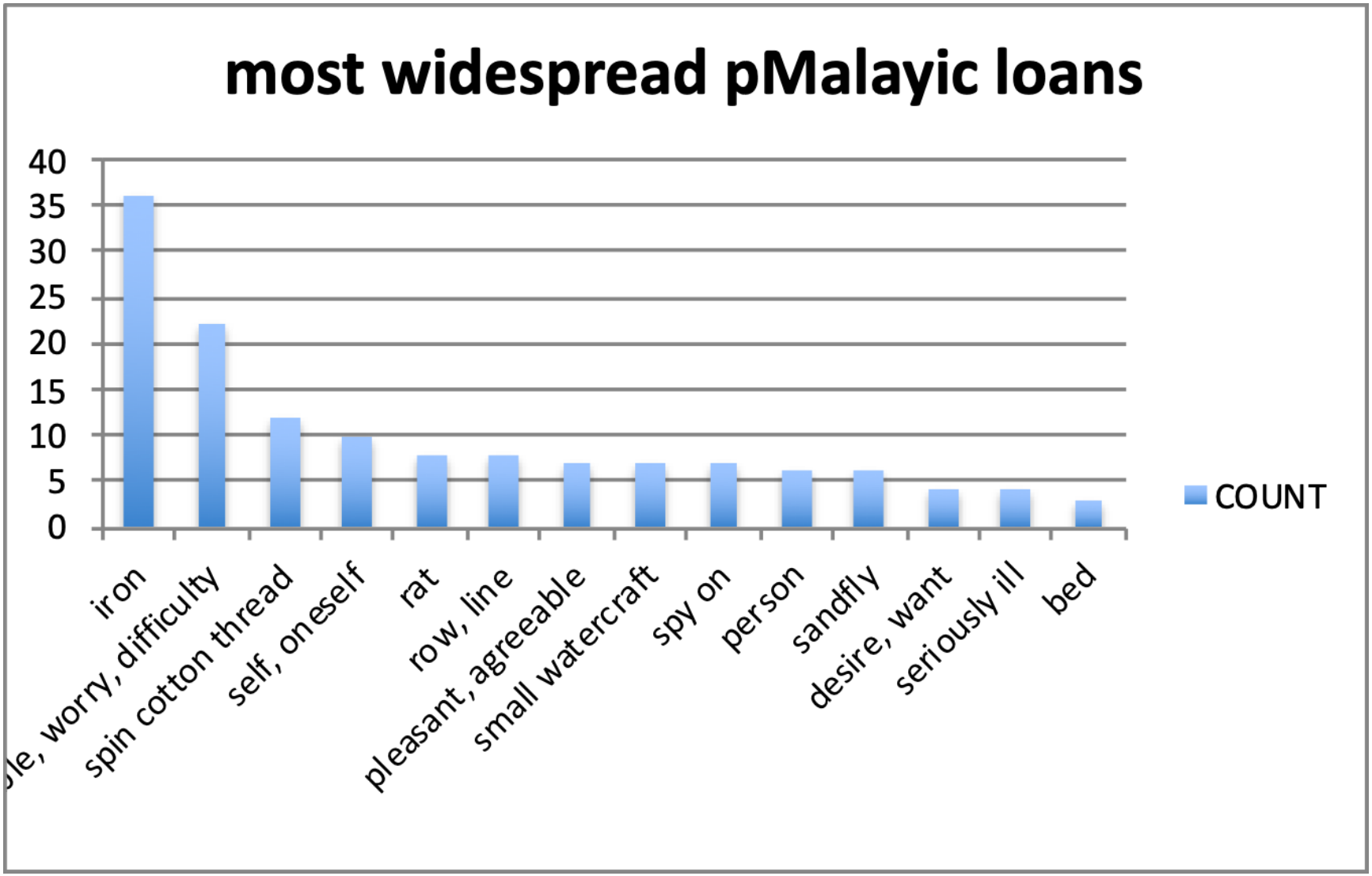
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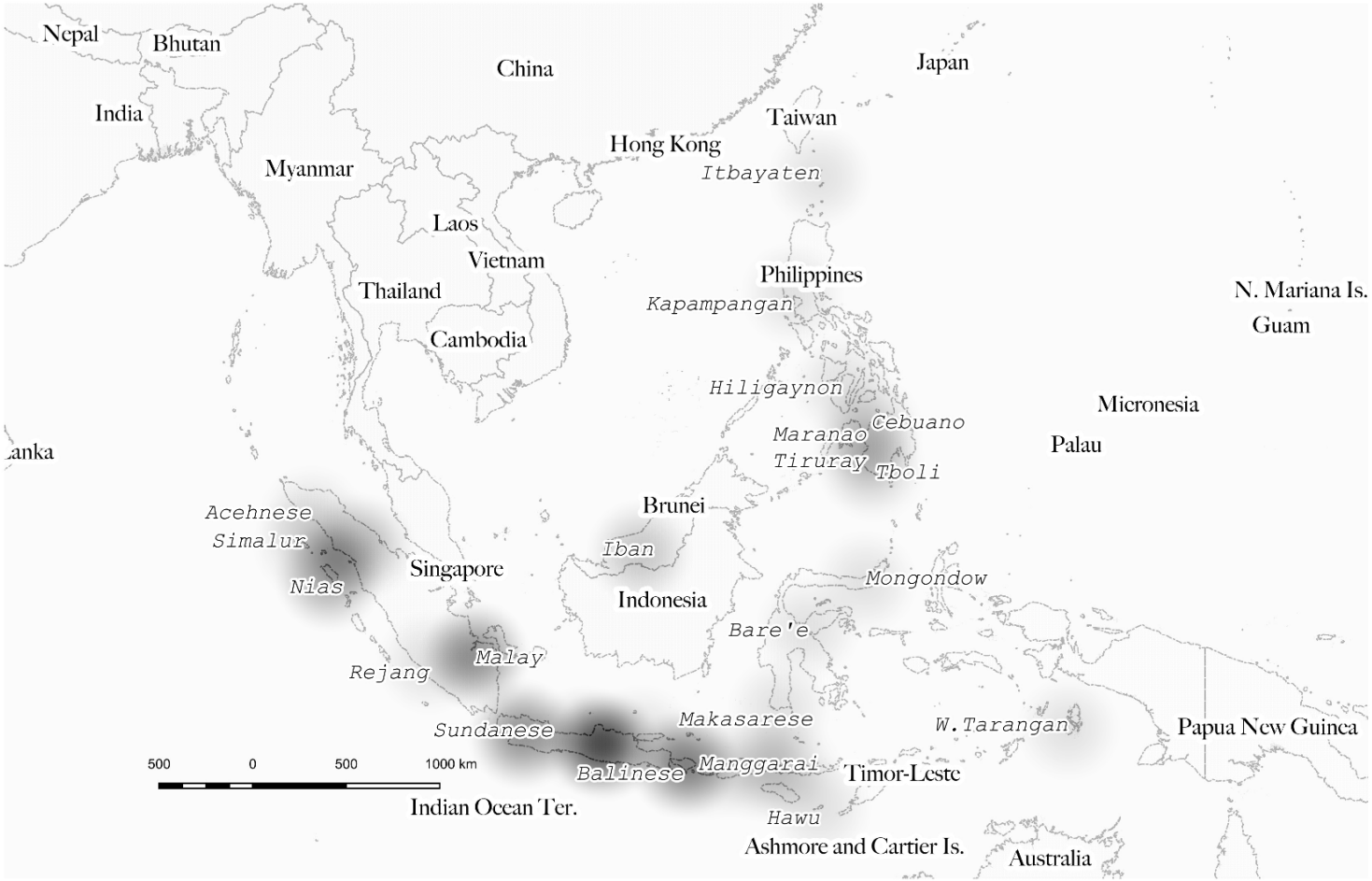
Lexical borrowing in Austronesian

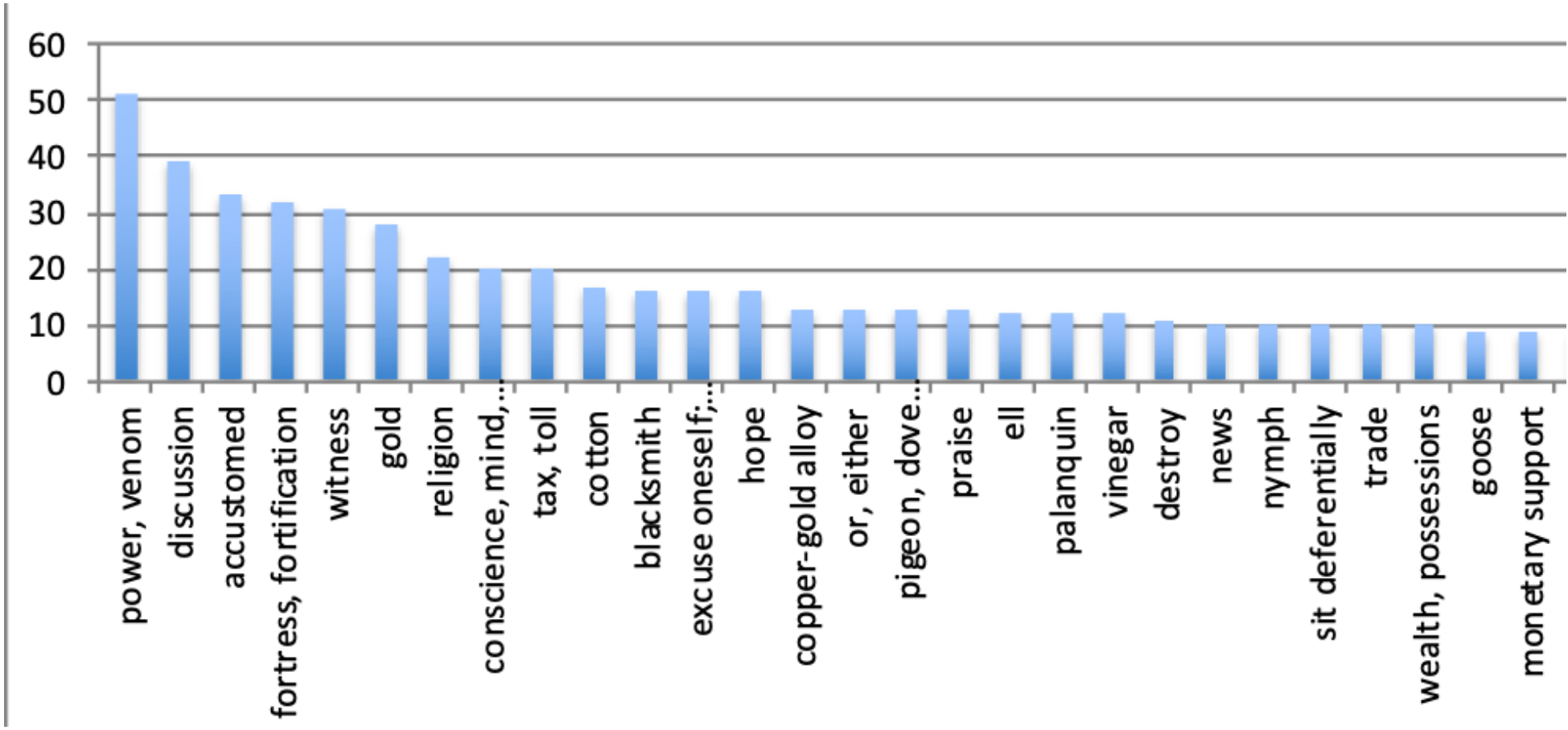


Malayic loanwords

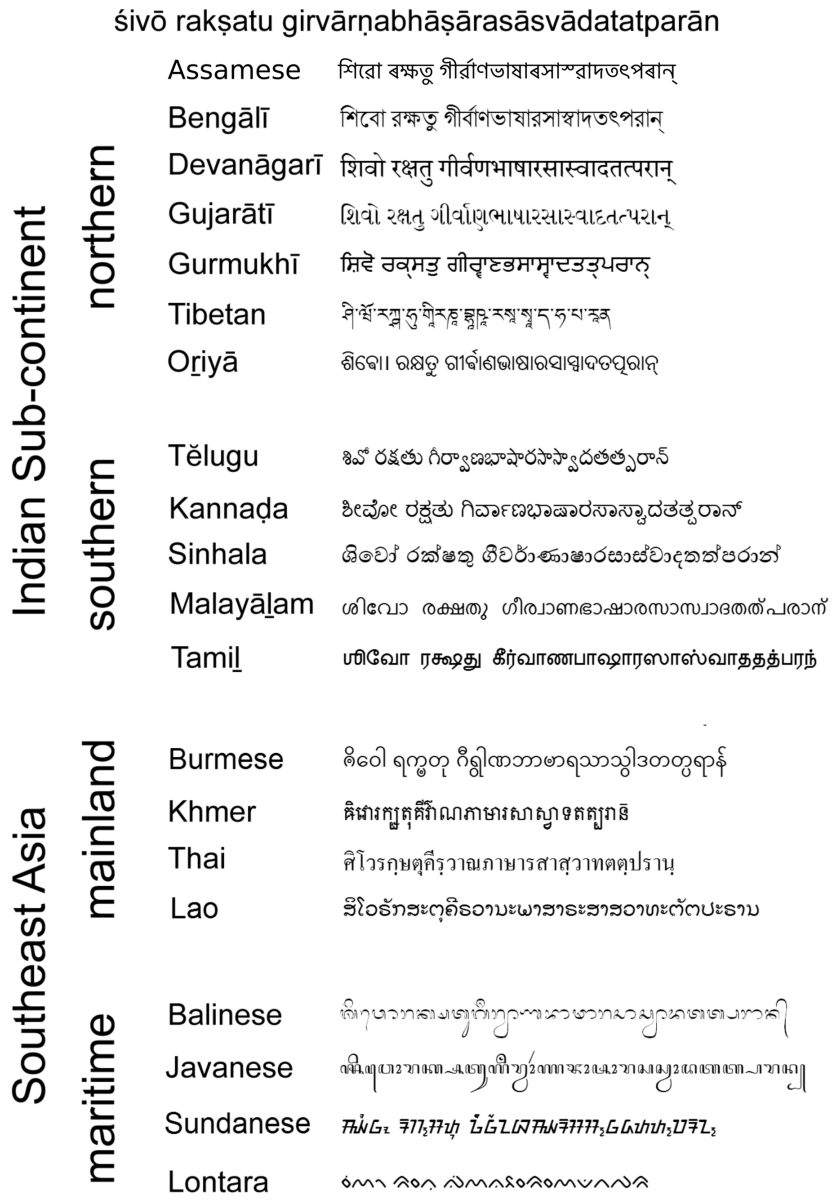


Indic loanwords





Indic loanwords — the 28 most widespread; the tail of another 29 is omitted



‘May Siva bless those who take delight in the language of the gods’ (Kālidāsa)

Image by Abhay Agarwal, via Wikimedia Commons (*Phrase sanskrit.png*), CC BY-SA 3.0

Grantha and Pallava scripts

Phoenician	Aramaic	Value	Brahmi	Value
𐤀	𐡀	*	𑀅	a
𐤁	𐡁	b [b]	𑀩	ba
𐤂	𐡂	g [g]	𑀓	ga
𐤃	𐡃	d [d]	𑀥	dha
𐤄	𐡄	h [h], M.L.	𑀳	ha
𐤅	𐡅	w [w], M.L.	𑀯	va
𐤆	𐡆	z [z]	𑀚	ja
𐤇	𐡇	ḥ [ħ]	𑀖	gha
𐤈	𐡈	ṭ [tˤ]	𑀣	tha
𐤉	𐡉	y [j], M.L.	𑀬	ya
𐤊	𐡊	k [k]	𑀓	ka
𐤋	𐡋	l [l]	𑀮	la
𐤌	𐡌	m [m]	𑀫	ma
𐤍	𐡍	n [n]	𑀦	na
𐤎	𐡎	s [s]	𑀱	ṣa
𐤏	𐡏	ʿ [ʕ], M.L.	𑀏	e
𐤐	𐡐	p [p]	𑀧	pa
𐤑	𐡑	ṣ [sˤ]	𑀘	ca
𐤒	𐡒	q [q]	𑀑	kha
𐤓	𐡓	r [r]	𑀭	ra
𐤔	𐡔	š [ʃ]	𑀰	śa
𐤕	𐡕	t [t]	𑀢	ta

Indian scripts are derived from Greco-Phoenitian alphabeth



Austronesian scripts derived from Indian

Kawi
(700-1500 AD)

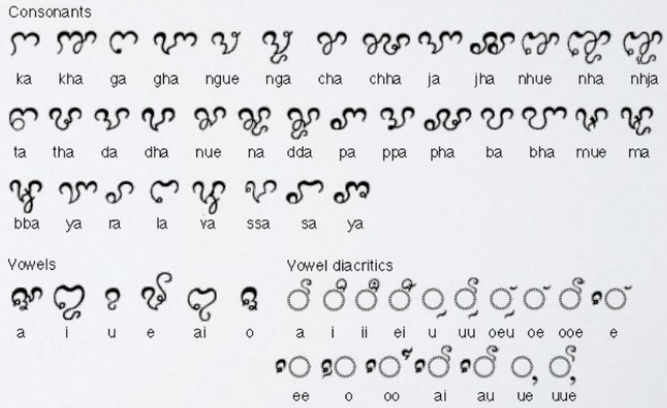


Javanese
(still in use)

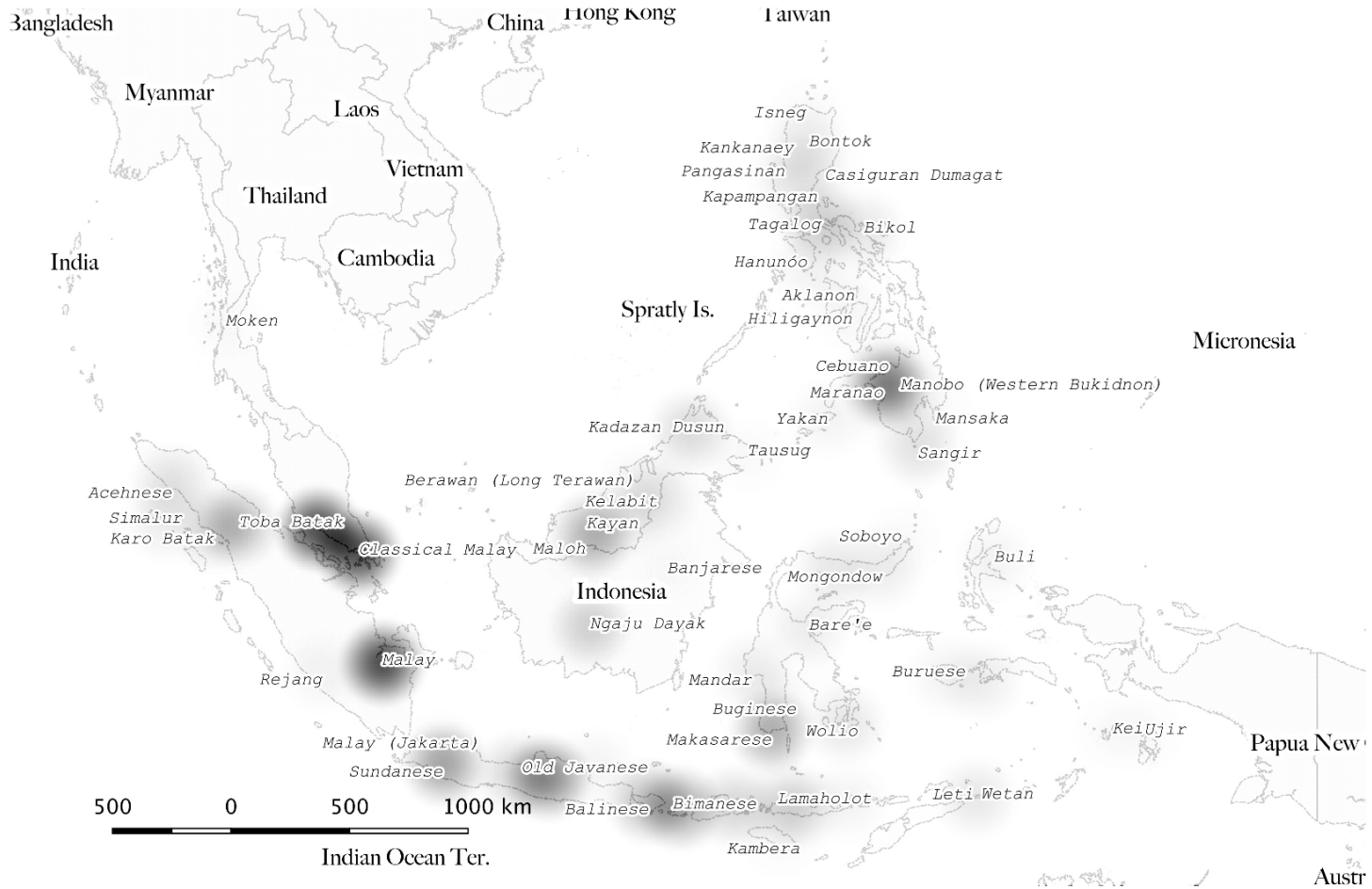


Balinese
(still in use)

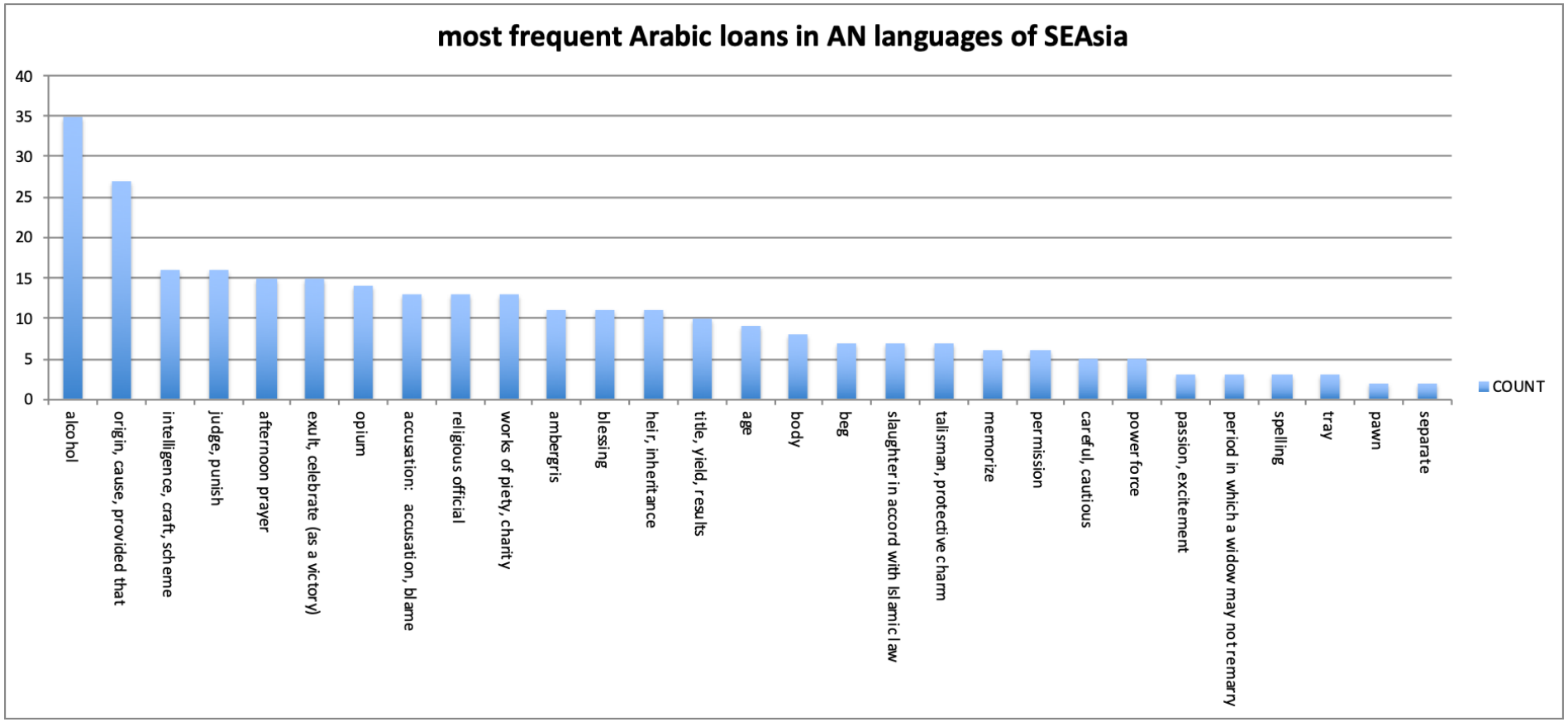
Cham
(still used)



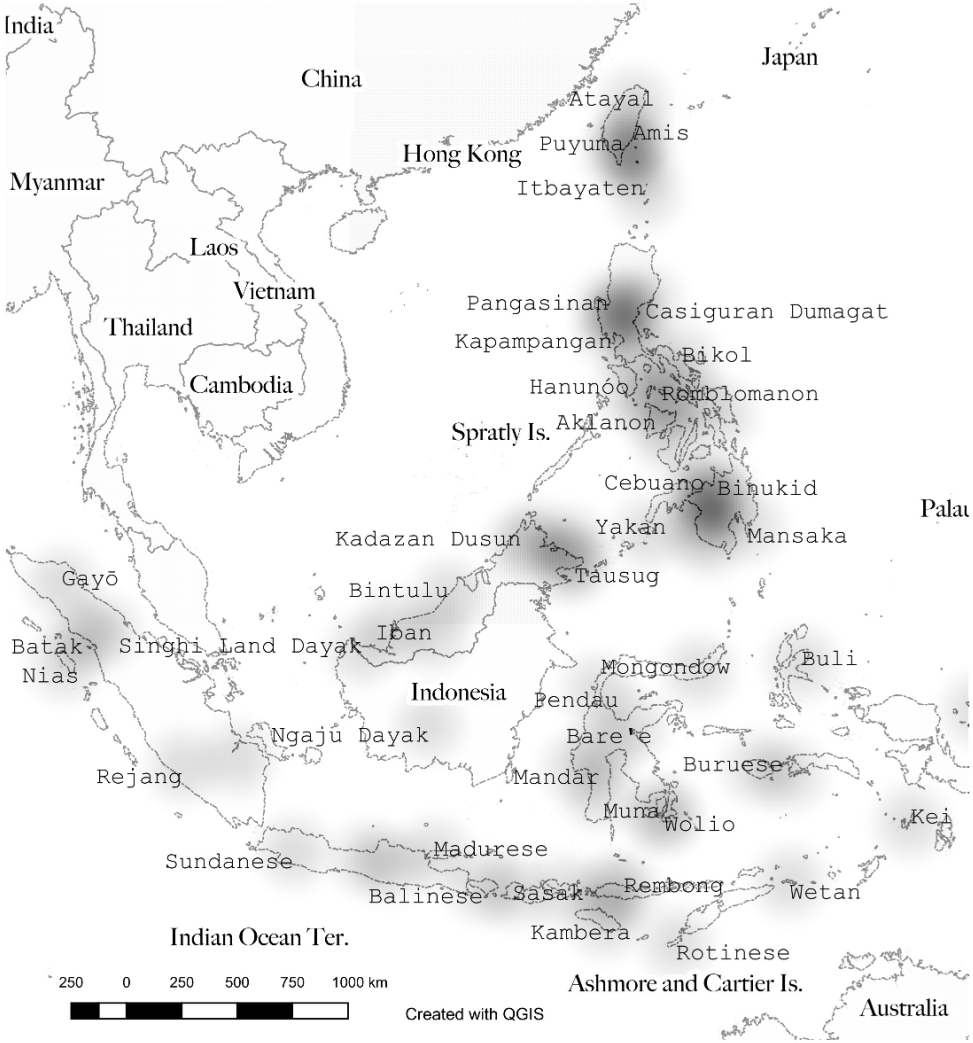
Arabic loanwords



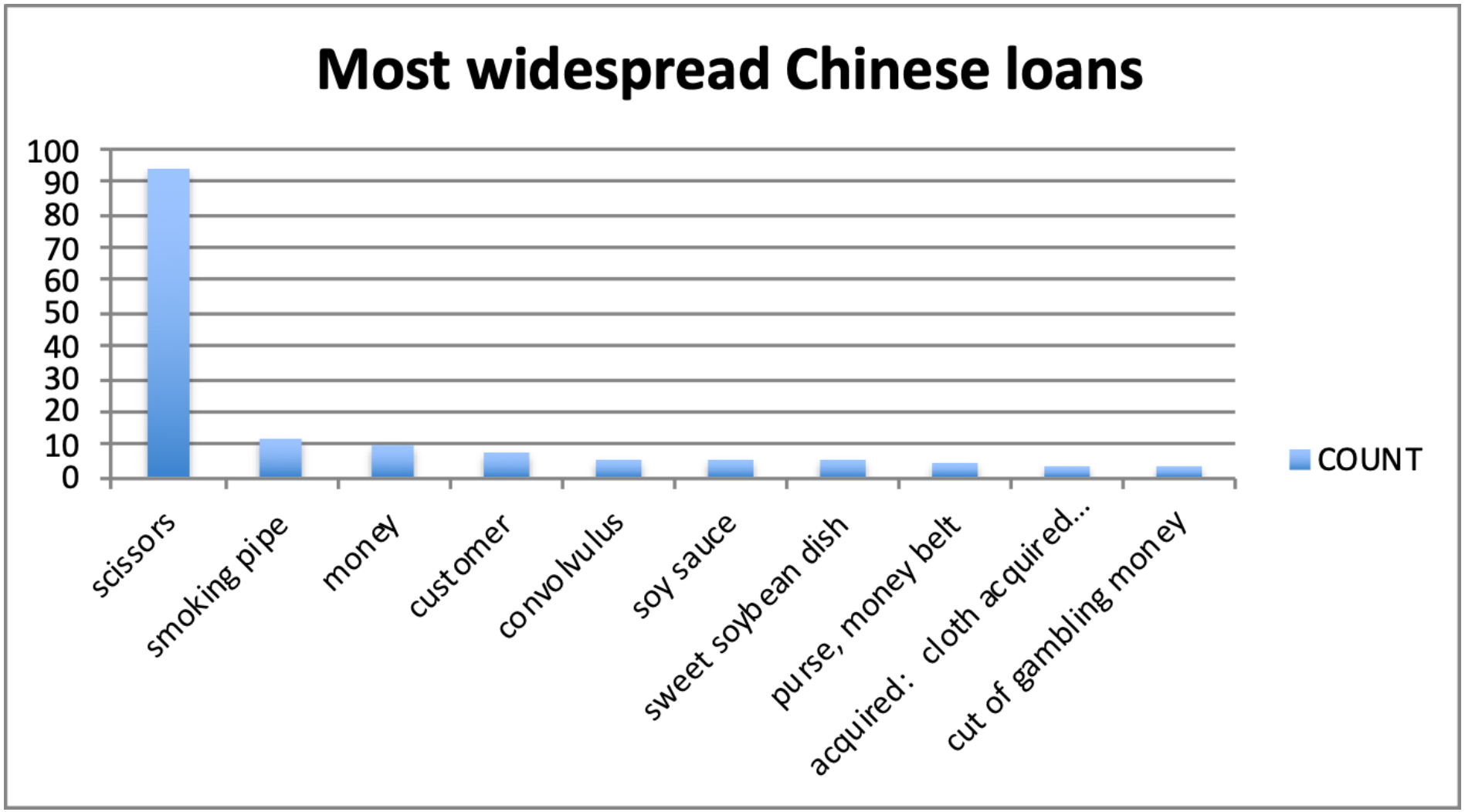
Arabic loanwords



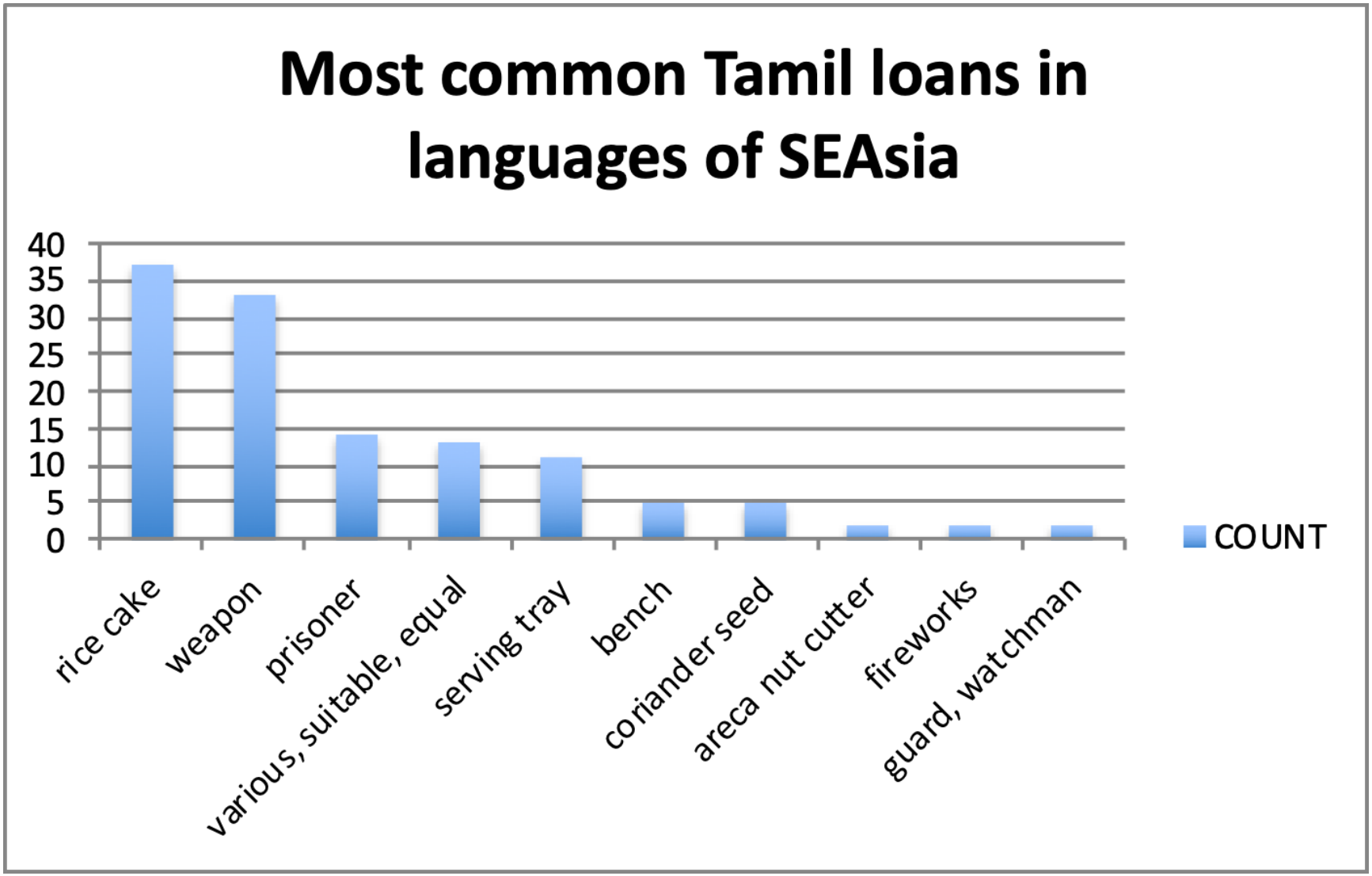
Chinese loanwords



Chinese loanwords



Tamil loanwords

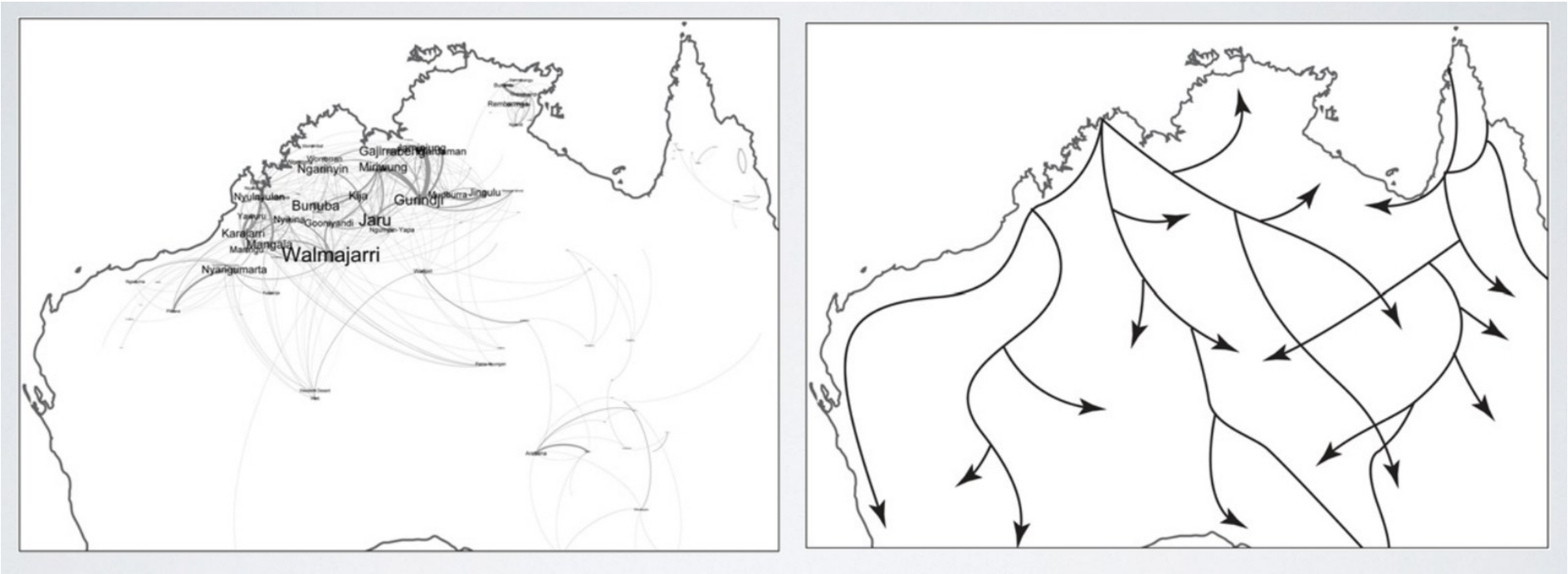


Wanderwörter

- A **Wanderwort** has travelled far beyond the family it started in, passed along trade routes rather than inherited
- Typically acculturation terms: trade goods, ritual objects, new technologies
  - few in number, but geographically enormous
- A nuisance for the comparative method: they look like cognates but are not, and can make unrelated languages look related
- Ones you already know: *tea* (Min *tê* by sea, Mandarin *chá* by land), *sugar*, *ginger*, *orange*
- In SEA, Malay was the vehicle: Sanskrit, Tamil, Persian and Arabic loans all rode it

Haynie et al. 2014

Wanderwörter in Australian languages



Left: which languages share loans, drawn as a network. **Right:** the **pearlshell** trade routes out of the Kimberley coast. The two maps have the same shape

Malay and Makassarese were lingua francas on this coast before the Europeans, and some Malay loans reach Arnhem Land

Haynie et al. 2014, figs. 4–5; trade routes after Stanton 1994

Outline

1 Language Families of Asia

2 South Asia

3 Geography and Climate

4 Crops and Domestication

5 Contact, Trade and Writing

6 Lexical Borrowing

7 Conclusion

Asia before colonial times

- The region is bounded by the Arabian Sea and Indian Ocean, the Pacific, and the Himalaya
- Throughout, the **monsoon** set what could be grown, when ships could sail, and so where people and languages went
- The modern language map is largely the map of early agriculturists expanding, channelled by obstacles (mountains, rainforest, sea) and gateways (river valleys, island chains, straits)
- Where they could not reach, diversity survived: **Zomia**, and the Papuan – Austronesian standoff in the east
- Contact (Indic, Sinitic, Arabic, Malay) has been continuous and multidirectional for millennia: loanwords, converged grammars, scripts, and whole languages abandoned
- By the start of our era the region was already linked to the Indic and Sinitic worlds, with Malay its lingua franca

Context is important

> *... the European colonial powers ... contributed merely the latest layer of color on the linguistically and culturally rich canvas of the region.*
>
> Coupe & Kratochvíl (2020: 42)

- English is not the first lingua franca, prestige language or source of loanwords here, only the most recent
- Malay held that role for almost two thousand years, displaced only around the Second World War
- Asian Englishes show the same three processes (borrowing, convergence, shift) running again

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  (the source of the rice maps and phylogenies above)

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- The figures are his, or are reproduced in his slides from the sources named on each slide and listed at the end
- Rebuilt and expanded by me (FCB): any errors introduced in the rebuilding are mine
- The same ground is covered at chapter length, with references, in Coupe & Kratochvíl (2020), *Asia before English*
- The Sanskrit-in-many-scripts figure is from Wikimedia Commons via Coupe & Kratochvíl (2020, Figure 2.5)
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